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"When they go low, we kick them":

The reciprocal nature of citizens' support for democratic transgressions[*, †]

Short Title: Reciprocating Democratic Transgressions

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Abstract

This study examines how citizens respond to democratic transgressions by political opponents and whether they, in turn, support reciprocal transgressions by their own party. Drawing on psychological theories of negative reciprocity, we argue that commitment to democratic principles is relational, shaped by the (un)democratic behavior of other political actors. Through survey experiments in England (N = 4,040) and the United States (N = 4,084), we find that exposure to opponents' transgressions more than doubles citizens' likelihood of endorsing undemocratic actions by their own party. Deductive coding of open-ended responses (N = 907) reveals that many justify reciprocal transgressions as a way to restore fairness and protect democracy from an uneven playing field. Our findings highlight the need for an interactive approach to the study of democratic violations that captures the dynamic and complex nature of citizens' attitudes towards undemocratic behavior.[††]

Keywords: democratic backsliding; democratic transgressions; reciprocity; support for democracy; fairness.

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[*] Replication files are available in the JOP Dataverse (https://dataverse.harvard.edu/dataverse/jop). The empirical analysis has been successfully replicated by the JOP replication analyst. Supplementary material for this article is available in the appendix in the online edition.

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"Michelle [Obama] always says, 'When they go low,
we go high.' No. No. When they go low, we kick them."

~ Eric Holder, former US Attorney General (2018)

Citizens' willingness to condone undemocratic behavior is a defining problem in today's democracies. A long line of scholarship emphasizes that public support is essential to democratic survival (e.g., Dahl 1956; Easton 1965; Lipset 1959). Citizens are expected to provide legitimacy to democratic institutions and constrain elites when they violate democratic norms, thereby serving as a last crucial bulwark against elite-driven autocratization (Weingast 1997; Wunsch and Gessler 2023). Yet, while many express strong support for democracy in the abstract (Wuttke et al. 2022), a growing body of research shows that citizens are willing to trade-off democratic principles for political gain (e.g., Aarslew 2023; Carey et al. 2022; Ferrer et al. 2025; Frederiksen 2022; Gidengil et al. 2022; Gidron et al. 2026; Simonovits et al. 2022). Indeed, a troubling pattern in (backsliding) democracies is that elites who undermine democratic principles rarely face meaningful electoral backlash (Graham and Svolik 2020; Wunsch and Gessler 2023). This has sparked a growing interest in why citizens fail to defend democratic institutions despite their stated commitment to them, with scholars exploring drivers such as rationalization (Krishnarajan 2023), different conceptions of democracy (Wunsch et al. 2025), and affective polarization (Voelkel et al. 2024).

In this study, we advance a different approach to explain citizens' antidemocratic attitudes, one that foregrounds the relational nature of political behavior. Whereas existing research has mostly studied citizens' attitudes towards democratic transgressions in isolated "clean slate" settings, we explicitly theorize and test the dependence of these attitudes on the conduct of other political actors. To that end, we develop a theoretical argument grounded in the concept of negative reciprocity: The practice of responding to negative behavior with similar negative behavior (i.e., an eye for an eye). Reciprocity has long been recognized as a

foundational feature of social life (Becker 1956; Gouldner 1960; Molm 2010). A vast body of research shows that the impulse to reciprocate is hardwired into the human brain, making it a strong and universal driver of human behavior (e.g., Chernyak et al. 2019). Negative reciprocity, in particular, reflects the belief that retaliation is a legitimate and appropriate response to perceived wrongdoing (Eisenberger et al. 2004). We extend this logic to the political domain, arguing that when political opponents violate the rules of the democratic game, citizens feel compelled to respond in kind. In other words, citizens are driven to *reciprocate* democratic violations. In this view, support for undemocratic actions is not formed in a vacuum but emerges as a reactive response to (perceived) transgressions by the other side.

In doing so, our theoretical framework complements existing research on the biased perceptions of opponents' willingness to support undemocratic practices (Braley et al. 2023; Druckman et al. 2023; Pasek et al. 2022). While this literature similarly emphasizes the interdependence of democratic commitments, it operates on a forward-looking logic: citizens are argued to preemptively adjust their own democratic commitments based on what they *expect* the other side to do. Instead, we argue that citizens look backward: Rather than anticipating undemocratic behavior, we examine how citizens react when democratic violations have actually occurred. This distinction is especially important as democratic erosion advances across the globe (Nord et al. 2026). In many countries, democratic violations are no longer anticipated but have become part of citizens' lived political reality. Theorizing on how citizens respond when such violations take place is crucial to understand when and why undemocratic attitudes gain traction amongst the general public in ongoing autocratization processes.

To test the role of reciprocity in shaping attitudes towards democratic transgressions, we conducted survey experiments in England (N = 4,040) and the US (N = 4,084). The experimental design introduces an interactive approach as it confronts respondents in the treatment group with fictional undemocratic behavior by the political opponent in vignettes. Following the treatment, respondents choose whether they think their in-party should engage

in behavior that mirrors the democratic violation or should not take any undemocratic action. We complement our experimental results with deductive coding of open questions to gain further insights into citizens' justifications for reciprocating democratic transgressions.

Our results show a clear pattern: Reciprocity is a powerful driver of support for democratic transgressions. Across both England and the US, we document large effect sizes, with respondents exposed to an opponent's democratic violation being more than *twice* as likely to endorse undemocratic acts by their own party. These findings are robust across a wide range of additional tests, including alternative operationalizations of the dependent variable, subgroup analyses, and primes designed to heighten awareness of democratic norms. Importantly, the tendency to reciprocate transgressions is not limited to highly polarized individuals or specific partisan groups. The absence of an interaction with affective polarization suggests that the impulse to reciprocate democratic violations is widespread, reflecting a broader tendency rather than a response confined to those with high partisan animosity.

In addition, we show that citizens reciprocate transgressions knowingly: Citizens do not endorse reciprocal undemocratic acts because they are simply unaware that it constitutes a breach of democratic rules. Rather, we find that informing citizens about the importance of key democratic principles does not change their impulse to reciprocate. Instead, based on respondents' self-reported motivations, we find that principles of fairness underlie the desire to respond in kind. Citizens express that mirroring the violation of the out-party allows them to restore balance within politics, essentially protecting democracy from an unequal playing field.

These findings have important implications for our understanding of citizens' commitment to democratic principles. First, they highlight that such commitment is malleable and conditional on the conduct of other parties in the political arena, underscoring the need for a relational perspective on democratic behavior. Studying these attitudes in isolation risks misinterpreting citizens' antidemocratic support in contexts where they encounter violations by the other side. This insight resonates with theoretical accounts of democratic stability that stress

the importance of mutual tolerance and shared commitments among political actors (Helmke et al. 2022; Levitsky and Ziblatt 2018; Schedler 2021; Weingast 1997). Second, by rooting our interactive approach in the well-established need for negative reciprocity, we offer a new and deeper psychological understanding of why democratic violations can ignite further undemocratic reactions. Our study highlights that many citizens experience a deeper trade-off – one between their commitment to democracy and their adherence to principles of reciprocity and fairness – that goes beyond mere self-interest as previous studies have often suggested. This insight implies that citizens do not (only) support reciprocal transgressions out of ill intent or because democratic violations have become normalized, but from a belief that reciprocation is the democratic and just thing to do.

Explaining anti-democratic attitudes

Healthy and stable democracies are predicated on the support of their citizens (Easton 1965). Scholars have long emphasized the importance of public support in maintaining democratic stability (e.g., Dahl 1956; Lipset 1959), arguing that when citizens' support for democracy erodes, so may democracy itself (Claassen 2020). Within democratic systems, citizens serve as a vital 'vertical' check: When elites violate democratic principles, they can be held accountable through the withdrawal of popular support. In that light, scholars have argued that citizens represent "the last bulwark against the systematic dismantling of checks and balances by overbearing executives" (Wunsch and Gessler 2023, p. 914).

But do citizens possess the strong, principled democratic commitments to fulfill this role? So far, the verdict is mixed. A burgeoning literature has emerged that studies an apparent conflict between citizens' strong commitment to democracy on paper (Wuttke et al. 2022; Holliday et al. 2024) and their willingness to trade-off democratic principles for political gain. Citizens are prepared to restrict the civil liberties of people they disagree with (Crawford and Pilanski 2014), they are inclined to vote for undemocratic candidates that align with their party

preferences (Graham and Svolik 2020), and they are willing to accept flawed democratic processes as long as they are on the winning side (Werner et al. 2025). This paints a paradoxical picture: Citizens profess to hold sincere democratic attitudes across a wide range of survey studies, but when push comes to shove, they are willing to condone democratic violations.

Scholars have advanced various reasons as to why people may not defend democratic principles despite a general commitment to democracy. The most prevalent one is that citizens can identify democratic transgressions but simply prioritize other goals, such as partisan victories or policy outcomes (e.g. Frederiksen 2022; Graham and Svolik 2020; Simonovits et al. 2022). They might prefer democratic over undemocratic behavior, ceteris paribus, but when faced with a trade-off between democratic procedures and political outcomes, they are willing to overlook transgressions. Another explanation is that citizens suffer from perceptual biases that lead them to apply double standards in their evaluation of elite behavior (Krishnarajan 2023). Through rationalization, citizens might not consciously give up on democratic norms but rather "find ways to convince themselves that they are getting their desired policy *and* democracy." (Krishnarajan 2023, p. 474). A related argument is that different understandings of democracy may explain this conflict (Wunsch et al. 2025), as power grabs by popularly elected officials may be seen as consistent with a majoritarian definition of democracy.

We build on this literature but add a more interactive element to explain citizens' support for undemocratic measures. We argue that the perceived acceptability of undemocratic behavior is not only based on citizens' intrinsic interests, perceptions, or understandings, but that it is also contingent on the behavior of other parties. This interactive logic aligns with recent work showing that people's democratic commitments are shaped by perceptions of opponents' willingness to support undemocratic practices (Braley et al. 2023; Druckman et al. 2023; Pasek et al. 2022). Braley et al. (2023) conceptualize this dynamic as the 'subversion dilemma': Citizens become more willing to defect from democratic principles when they expect political opponents will do the same. While this literature highlights the fundamentally

interdependent nature of democratic commitments, it operates on a forward-looking logic centered on anticipated democratic subversion (akin to a prisoner's dilemma). Our approach is theoretically distinct in two respects. First, we shift attention from anticipation to reaction: citizens are not updating beliefs about what opponents might do in the future, but responding to what they have already done. In doing so, we highlight citizens' immediate reactionary impulse in contexts where democratic transgressions are actively unfolding. Second, and relatedly, we propose a distinct psychological mechanism grounded in negative reciprocity. We posit that when political opponents violate democratic norms, citizens become more willing to support democratic transgressions by their own side in response. In this view, support for undemocratic behavior emerges not only from partisan bias or strategic expectations about future opponent conduct, but from a backward-looking impulse to reciprocate perceived democratic wrongdoing and restore fairness after the rules of the political game were broken.

Reciprocity in the Context of Democratic Transgressions

A large body of research has shown that reciprocity is a universal and powerful driver of human behavior: Studies spanning diverse academic disciplines (e.g., psychology, biology, economics, anthropology), employing a wide range of methodological approaches, as well as covering varied cultural contexts, consistently underscore the omnipresence of reciprocal behavior (e.g., Falk et al. 2008; Fehr and Gächter 2000; Gouldner 1960; Molm 2010; Nowak and Sigmund 2005). The norm of reciprocity is so hardwired within our thinking that it is considered one of *the* defining features of social life (Molm 2010). Indeed, Becker (1956) has even referred to our species as the "homo reciprocus" (p. 1). While the concept of reciprocity is not undebated, it is widely understood as the practice of *offering a response in kind* (i.e., tit for tat, quid pro quo) (Fehr and Gächter 2000). Central to the practice of reciprocity is a pattern of mutually contingent exchange that ensures a symmetry of giving and taking in social life (Schedler

2021). Importantly, the innate human need for reciprocity is not confined to rational utility calculations and occurs even if it is not in people's self-interest (Nowak and Sigmund 2005).

Our argument regarding reciprocity in the context of democratic transgressions builds specifically on theories about *negative* reciprocity. 'Positive' reciprocity is commonly defined as a social practice that obligates people to repay favorable treatment (Eisenberger et al. 2004). 'Negative' reciprocity, in contrast, incorporates a retaliation principle in which "the emphasis is placed not on the return of benefits but on the return of injuries" (Gouldner 1960, p. 172). It is thus rooted in the widely known principle of 'an eye for an eye'. Negative reciprocity comprises a belief that retribution is a legitimized and proper way to respond to unfavorable treatment (Eder et al. 2006). Scholars have shown that negative reciprocity is deeply embedded in our social interactions and that propensities to punish harmful behavior (i.e., negative reciprocity) are even stronger than propensities to reward favorable behavior (i.e., positive reciprocity) (Chernyak et al. 2019; Shaw et al. 2019). The dynamics of negative reciprocity are documented in a plethora of contexts, ranging from counter-cheating in marital relationships (Jefferson et al. 2024) to reciprocal tariffs in interstate trade wars (Mattoo and Staiger 2019).

While negative reciprocity is thus a broadly observed human tendency, we argue that the political domain presents a particularly fertile ground for its dynamics to unfold. As a highly social and interactive arena, politics brings the norms governing interpersonal relations to the forefront. Furthermore, its competitive nature and high stakes heighten people's sensitivity to perceived inequalities, thereby increasing the propensity to reciprocate unfavorable acts (Shaw et al. 2019). Despite the theoretical appeal of reciprocity as a driving logic of political behavior (see Schedler 2021), we know surprisingly little about citizens' reciprocation tendencies in politics. Indeed, reciprocity "is a relatively underexamined phenomenon with, to date, little direct application to the political sphere" (Eder et al. 2006, p. 810).

In this paper, we apply the concept of negative reciprocity to the specific context of undemocratic behavior. Democratic principles serve as foundational rules of the political game.

When those rules are violated by political opponents, citizens can feel mistreated which activates people's innate tendency to reciprocate (Gouldner 1960). The central premise of our argument is thus that when faced with undemocratic acts of political opponents, the need for negative reciprocity compels citizens to engage in a tit-for-tat response, meaning that they come to support similar undemocratic acts by their own political camp. Importantly, negative reciprocity is a response to the *sense* of being harmed (Falk et al. 2008). Citizens do not need to witness factual undemocratic acts by political opponents to trigger these reactions: Merely perceiving the other side as having violated democratic norms (Braley et al. 2023; Krishnarajan 2023) – whether or not this is objectively true – can be sufficient to initiate a reciprocal reaction.

Anecdotal evidence at the elite-level offers illustrative support for our theory that democratic violations tend to be reciprocated (Helmke et al. 2022). A prominent example is the debate over court-packing in the US (Neal 2020). Following Republican efforts to block Obama's Supreme Court nominee in 2016 and accelerate the confirmation of a conservative justice under Trump, many Democrats began advocating for expanding the Supreme Court once back in power - explicitly framing this move as retaliatory and as "the only way to restore balance to the court and protect US democracy" (Kapur 2021). Similar tit-for-tat dynamics are evident in the use of gerrymandering. These elite-level interactions reflect a logic of negative reciprocity that mirrors the patterns we theorize at the citizen-level.

It is important to note, however, that we do not study interpersonal reciprocity among elites or horizontal retaliation between citizens. Instead, we focus on a *vertical* reciprocity: how citizens evaluate elite-level violations and how reciprocity shapes expectations for how their preferred party should respond. This dimension is particularly important given citizens' central role in protecting democracies through *vertical accountability*. By shedding light on how reciprocity norms influence this evaluative function, we contribute to understanding when and why citizens may fail to constrain undemocratic elite behavior. Again, vertical reciprocity too has clear real-world parallels. A striking example is California's so-called Election Rigging

Response Act, which was explicitly framed as a response to Republican gerrymandering in Texas and passed with 64.4% of the public vote, underscoring the importance of citizens' views in enabling the reciprocation of undemocratic practices (Jeong 2025). On this basis, we formulate the central hypothesis: *Respondents who are exposed to a democratic transgression perpetrated by a political opponent are more supportive of a (reciprocal) democratic transgression by the own party as compared to respondents who are not exposed to a democratic transgression perpetrated by a political opponent.*

Motivations for reciprocating democratic transgressions

There are different reasons why citizens might want elites to reciprocate democratic transgressions. For instance, voters may feel the need to re-establish an equilibrium in fairness (Rabin 1993). Reciprocal transgressions are then viewed as a way to remedy a perceived injustice, stemming from feeling wronged and mistreated by the opponent's prior breach of rules. When reciprocal violations are motivated by fairness, they intend to level the playing field of the democratic game. Reciprocal transgressions, from this perspective, are seen as the right and democratic thing to do: They provide an opportunity to even the score, restore balance in the democratic system, and prevent a greater harm – an unfair advantage for the other side – from occurring (for a related argument on democratic rationalization, see Krishnarajan 2023). This fairness-based motivation also highlights the democratic ambiguity of reciprocation, as actions intended to protect fairness and democratic balance themselves contribute to support for undemocratic behavior, a paradox to which we return in the conclusion.

Another potential explanation is rooted in the desire for revenge (see Riaz et al. 2024). Perceptions that the political opponent has violated democratic principles can instill feelings of anger, leading voters to seek emotional release through retaliation (Jackson et al. 2019). Under these conditions, reciprocal transgressions specifically *target* the political opponent: What

satisfies the reciprocal transgressor purely motivated by revenge is not the perceived restoration of justice within their democracy, but the suffering of the opponent for their initial provocation.

Last, exposure to a democratic defection could also initiate a process of normalization in which citizens adjust their perceptions of what constitutes appropriate and prevalent democratic conduct. Normalization is a largely subconscious process that can have a significant, but hidden, impact on citizens' beliefs (Bicchieri 2017). It can drive support for reciprocal transgressions by causing a shift in democratic norms, in which measures that were once viewed as violations of democracy may come to be seen as normal or routine practices within politics (Clayton et al. 2021). Normalization can also manifest through a change in the perceived public pressures associated with voicing undemocratic preferences, reducing the tendency for preference falsification (Valentim 2026).

We do not consider the theoretical explanations that we propose for the reciprocation of transgressions to be mutually exclusive or exhaustive. Indeed, Weingast (1997) and Helmke et al. (2022) develop theoretical models on the interdependence of democratic norms rooted in rational choice and deterrence (i.e., the expectation that transgressors will be discouraged from further violations if they foresee retaliation). Our focus on fairness, revenge, and normalization reflects extensive evidence that people reciprocate even when doing so is not in their self-interest (e.g., Nowak and Sigmund 2005), which has led scholars to argue that rational-choice models are "unambiguously refuted" as the central explanation of reciprocity (Fehr and Gächter 2000, p. 160). Importantly, however, research indicates that citizens' reasons to reciprocate are complex and challenging to study, often arising from a combination of factors (Jackson et al. 2019). Hence, we refrain from formulating hypotheses about the individual mechanisms underlying reciprocity and examine these exploratorily in the results section.

Experimental design

To empirically investigate the existence of negative reciprocity in the context of democratic transgressions, we fielded two pre-registered survey experiments in England (May 28-June 16, 2024) and the US (August 27-September 4, 2024).[1] Whereas the survey in England used quota sampling for gender and education, the survey in the US applied interlocked quotas for gender, age, and party affiliation. Prior research shows that Prolific provides high-quality data and that quota-based convenience samples yield valid and replicable insights, particularly when the focus is on experimental effects (Coppock 2019). Based on a priori power analyses using pilot data, we aimed for approximately 4,000 respondents per country, yielding well over 85% power to detect heterogeneous treatment effects. We planned for attenuated interaction effects that are half the size of the main effects documented in pilot tests. After data-cleaning, the final sample sizes are 4,040 and 4,084 respondents in England and the US, respectively.[2] Supplementary Information (SI) B provides more information about the composition of our samples.

England and the US are suitable cases for testing our argument as they are majoritarian democracies where two main parties typically alternate in power, allowing for a relatively straightforward design with clear in- and out-groups. England and the US, however, also differ in various important ways. Although two parties dominate English politics, it still functions as a multi-party system, with Reform UK gaining ground in recent years. We focus specifically on England rather than the UK to avoid complicating our design with regional party dynamics (e.g., SNP in Scotland). England and the US also differ in their experience with democratic transgressions and backsliding in the years leading up to our data collection: While our

[1] Both experiments were pre-registered (see SI A for more details), approved by the IRB of the host institution (anonymized for review), and an anonymized replication package is available at OSF.

[2] We excluded 52 respondents in England and 141 in the US before randomization for not providing consent or failing attention checks. Another 49 respondents in England were screened out for not holding English nationality.

experiment was conducted before Trump's second term, the US had already undergone substantial democratic backsliding between 2016 and 2020. England, by contrast, had not experienced autocratization to the same degree (Coppedge et al. 2025). Examining our argument in both contexts therefore allows us to evaluate whether reciprocity tendencies hold in countries that share institutional features yet differ in recent democratic trajectories.

Our case selection also has implications for the generalizability of our findings. On the one hand, we examine reciprocity dynamics in long-standing democracies where democratic attitudes are presumably more deeply rooted (Hernández 2016), potentially offering a more conservative test of our theory. On the other hand, research shows that reciprocity depends on the number of actors involved in an exchange (Boyd and Richerson 1988), with diffusion of responsibility and free-rider problems weakening reciprocation in multiparty contexts. Insofar as both England and the US approximate two-party systems, our design may therefore be more conducive to detecting reciprocity effects than studies set in more fragmented contexts.

Procedure

After participants accepted the study on Prolific, they were directed to a web questionnaire and surveyed on their demographics, political attitudes, and level of affective polarization. Next, respondents were randomly assigned to either the treatment or control condition. The treatment group was presented with a screen with a hypothetical democratic transgression by a political opponent.[3] The control group was not presented with any vignette and instead, moved on directly to answer questions on their support for democratic transgressions. Although demand-effects cannot be ruled out entirely, our between-subject design is less vulnerable to it and the open-ended answers provided no indication that respondents inferred the study's purpose.

[3] We use hypothetical democratic transgressions to avoid deception, while maintaining experimental control. Hypothetical scenarios are common in experimental research and are shown to perform well at predicting real-world attitudes (Aarslew 2023; Hainmueller et al. 2015).

Moreover, this design allows us to empirically test the difference between citizens' willingness to *react* undemocratically versus their willingness to *act* undemocratically. Specifically, the control group mirrors the approach of prior studies that measure anti-democratic attitudes in an isolated setting, without exposing respondents to the behavior of political opponents. As such, it provides a meaningful benchmark for testing our core theoretical claim: That support for undemocratic behavior increases after exposure to democratic violations by opponents.

As preregistered, a random subset of the sample (i.e., 20%) was presented with an additional vignette before being assigned to the treatment or control group in which they were informed about core democratic principles in their country, matching the principle under attack in the consequent treatment text and measures. This additional vignette serves to test whether citizens' willingness to reciprocate democratic defections remains when respondents are made explicitly aware that this behavior goes against democratic principles in their country.

Stimulus

As people may react differently to violations of different democratic principles, we randomly assign respondents to one of three types of hypothetical democratic transgressions. In the procedure of designing the vignettes, we considered three criteria that are essential for a valid test of our hypotheses: Severity, realism, and targeting.

Considering the severity of the transgression, it is crucial that the democratic vignettes present respondents with a scenario that is not too incremental, since a transgression without substantive impact on democracy may not spark a reaction among citizens. On the other hand, the democratic defection should also not be too severe, since this may drive respondents to question the realism of the vignette. In the 21st century, autocratization has become an ambiguous process in which democracy is gradually broken down, often behind a legal façade (Lührmann and Lindberg 2019). In order to match this current mode of subversion and maintain realism, we aimed for transgressions that constitute a clear breach of liberal democratic

principles but that alone do not dismantle democracy. To that end, we also focus specifically on democratic transgressions by *politicians,* reflecting the contemporary trend in which democratically elected elites erode democracy from within. In addition to considerations of severity and realism, an important criterion for the vignettes is that they need to *target* the political opponent for reciprocal defections to be sensible. Negative reciprocity occurs when one feels wronged by the actions of another and decides to reciprocate against the perceived wrongdoer (Eisenberger et al. 2004). The transgression presented in the vignette must thus directly harm respondents' preferred party in order for them to feel negatively affected.

Based on these criteria, we selected the following transgressions: (1) taking action to prohibit protests by the political opponent, (2) proposing a law to restrict the voting rights of supporters of the opposing party, and (3) denying access to critical media during a press release (see SI, Table C1). These acts represent violations of liberal democratic norms rather than violations of the law per se (Ahmed 2023) and are grounded in real-world political events in both countries. SI O provides an overview of these real-life examples and shows respondents' high realism ratings of the vignettes. Given the real-world occurrence of these violations, as well as evidence that citizens overestimate opponents' willingness to subvert democracy (Braley et al. 2023), respondents in the control group may already perceive the opponent as having engaged in democratic transgressions. This pre-existing perception could lead to partial activation of reciprocity tendencies prior to the experiment, making the observed differences between control and treatment groups a more conservative estimate of the treatment effect.

Each transgression targets a key democratic principle: banning protests undermines the right to peaceful assembly, restricting voting rights violates electoral equality, and excluding media harms press freedom. Prior work shows that Americans value all three principles, though to a varying degree: Equal voting rights are among the most crucial democratic elements, while the toleration of protests is deemed somewhat less essential, and non-interference with the press even less so (Carey et al. 2019). Our data corroborate these findings (SI Table B1).

An example vignette with the corresponding dependent variable is presented in Table 1 (SI C provides further details on the vignettes and question-wordings). Which party appears as the respondent's in- or out-party in the vignette is determined by their pre-treatment responses. In both countries, respondents indicate which of the two major parties – Labour or the Conservatives, and Democrats or Republicans – they like the most. The least-liked of the two parties is treated as the respondent's political opponent in the vignettes, meaning that the treatment group sees an undemocratic act committed by that party. We focus in the vignettes on the two major parties in England because using transgressions by minor parties risks weakening the realism of the vignette and perceived credibility of the democratic threat. Nonetheless, to acknowledge the multi-party context in England, we deduce respondents' in-party from a question in which respondents rank five political parties (i.e., Labour, Conservatives, Liberal Democrats, Reform UK, and the Greens) from most to least liked.

Importantly, the credibility of the vignette might depend on whether the respondent's political opponent is in power at the time of data collection. To that end, we phrased the hypothetical undemocratic acts as initiatives or proposals - rather than fully implemented actions - so that it remains plausible for both governing and opposition parties to engage in them. Moreover, empirical tests show that treatment effects are independent of party affiliation and winner-loser status (see Figure 3 and SI F).

Table 1. Example vignette and dependent variable: Equal voting rights

	Vignette and question wording
Vignette (Treatment only)	Imagine the following: Politicians from [out-party] have taken action to pass a law that would make it more difficult for supporters of [in-party] to cast their vote during the next election. Politicians from [in-party] are now discussing how they should respond to this act
Dependent variable (Treatment and control)	Amongst politicians of [in-party], there is a discussion about how they should handle voting rules in the [UK/US]. What would you like to see them do? I) Politicians from [in-party] *should take action* to pass a law that would make it more difficult for supporters of [out-party] to cast their vote during the next election. II) Politicians from [in-party] *should not take action* to pass a law that would make it more difficult for supporters of [out-party] to cast their vote during the next election. III) Don't know

Measurements

After respondents read the vignette, we measure our main dependent variable, which is whether citizens support democratic transgressions by the own party. To that end, we create a survey item covering either the democratic principle of protesting, voting rights, or freedom of the press. Table 1 presents an example of the wording for equal voting rights. We first inform respondents that their favored party is discussing how to handle protests, voting rules, or critical media in their country. This sentence serves to reduce social desirability bias by highlighting that politicians may hold diverse views on the issue and that there is not one 'correct' answer. Next, we ask respondents to select which action they prefer their in-party to take. Given that reciprocity is about offering a response in kind, respondents can choose to endorse a (reciprocal) democratic transgression that mirrors the undemocratic act shown in the treatment-vignette, reject the (reciprocal) democratic transgression, or indicate that they are unsure which response they prefer. In line with the recommendations of Westwood et al. (2022), we include a don't know option to prevent overestimation of support for undemocratic behavior (selected by 10.5% in England and 6.8% in the US). After answering this question, respondents are asked to provide a motivation for their answer in an open-ended question. This open-ended question provides a space for respondents to freely write down their justifications and is crucial in examining the reasons why citizens reciprocate transgressions.

A potential limitation of our dependent variable is that it presents respondents with a choice between endorsing a reciprocal transgression, rejecting it, or selecting "don't know." While this structure captures our core aim of identifying whether citizens wish to reciprocate or not, it does not encompass the full range of possible procedural or political responses. To address this concern, we supplement our analysis with more established candidate-choice measures (US only) and a scale capturing support for escalated reciprocal transgressions (see SI G and H, respectively). Across all measures, we observe consistent patterns, suggesting that our core findings are robust to alternative operationalizations.

Results

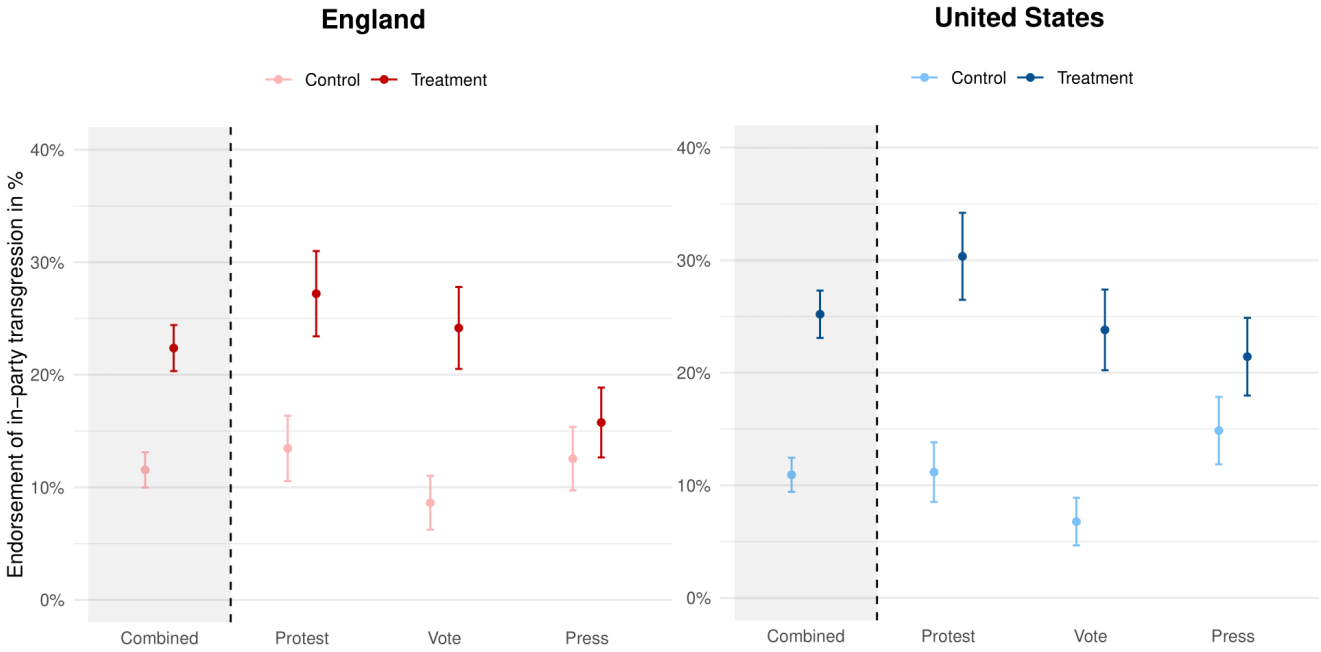
Do citizens reciprocate democratic defections? First, we present the means across treatment groups to gain insights into the overall baseline endorsement of undemocratic measures and the magnitude of the treatment effects. Figure 1 presents these descriptive results, showing the percentage of respondents who endorse a (reciprocal) democratic transgression in England and the United States across the control and treatment groups, both for the pooled results and for each vignette independently (i.e., protests, voting rights, and freedom of the press).[4]

Overall, the baseline support levels for undemocratic actions by the own party are relatively low: Among those in the control group, 11.5% in England and 10.9% in the US express a preference for their party to engage in undemocratic acts. This finding aligns with previous studies: Although citizens are often willing to tolerate undemocratic behavior for political gain (Graham and Svolik 2020)[5], only a small fraction of the population explicitly endorses undemocratic measures when asked directly (e.g., Holliday et al. 2024; Westwood et al. 2022). While it is important to emphasize that the vast majority of citizens prefer their party to uphold democratic integrity, the fact that one in ten people express unprovoked support for democratic transgressions still speaks to a normatively troubling minority preference.

[4] Following our preregistration, the samples differ across Figures 1–4. For the primary test of H1, we exclude respondents assigned to the democracy-information vignette. We further preregistered that, should this condition yield no substantively different results, these respondents would be included in the interaction analyses to ensure sufficient statistical power. For transparency, we report a replication of Figure 1 on the full sample in the SI D.

[5] Direct measures and trade-off designs tap into different forms of democratic commitment: explicit endorsement of undemocratic behavior versus willingness to overlook such behavior in pursuit of partisan goals. As such, trade-off designs impose a higher threshold for democratic responses, as respondents must bear a political cost to uphold democracy, such as defecting from their preferred party. This contributes to the comparatively higher levels of tolerance for democratic transgressions observed in such studies and presumably in real-life contexts.

Turning to our first hypothesis, the expected reciprocal effect is clearly visible. As hypothesized, we find that the percentage of respondents who endorse democratic violations by the own political camp is larger when they have previously been exposed to a violation by a political opponent. More concretely, when respondents are informed about a democratic transgression by the political opponent, the percentages double from 11.5% to 22.4% in England and from 10.9% to 25.2% in the US. In sum, we find strong support for our argument on the role of reciprocity: When the opponent has broken the rules of the political game, citizens support transgressions by the own party in return. These conclusions are further supported by multinomial regression models presented in SI D, which show strong and highly significant treatment effects on respondents' support for reciprocal transgressions (results are robust to OLS specifications, see SI D). We thus confirm H1, where we expected a significant difference in citizens' support for a breach of democratic principles depending on whether they were previously exposed to a democratic transgression perpetrated by a political opponent.



Fg 1. Percentage of respondents who support (reciprocal) transgressions.

Note: Error bars present 95% CIs. For the combined results, N = 3,202 in England and N = 3,276 in the US. As pre-registered, respondents receiving the additional vignette about core democratic principles are excluded. Model estimates are reported in SI Table D1.

Alt text: Two side-by-side dot plots with error bars, for England and the US, showing control and treatment estimates of percentage endorsement of in-party transgression across the combined sample and three vignettes, with treatment consistently higher.

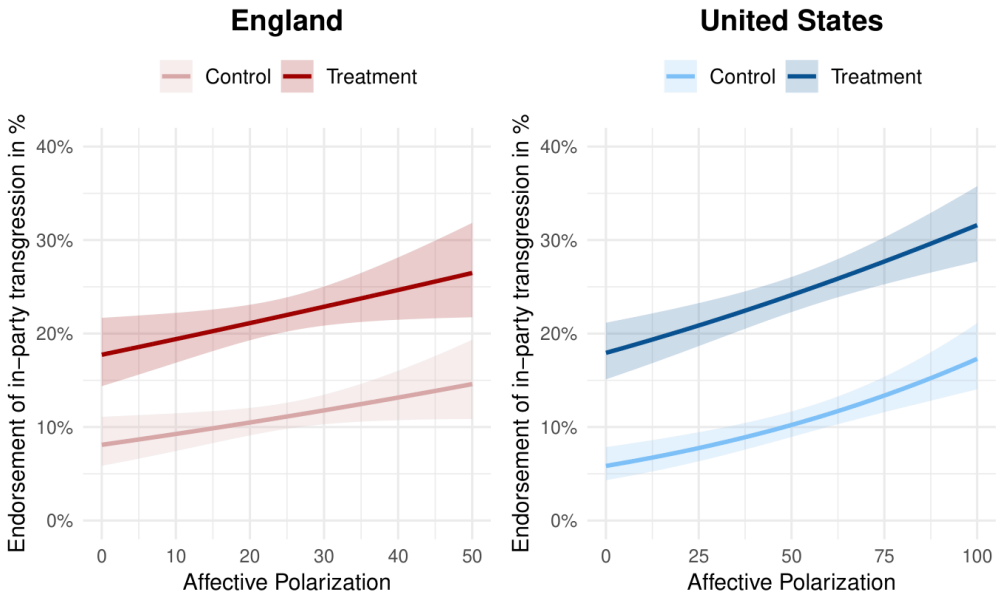
Looking at the different transgression-types individually, we find strong support for reciprocal reactions for protesting and voting rights in both England and the US. On both topics, the percentage of respondents selecting an undemocratic response more than doubles for the treatment group as compared to the control group. The effect sizes are especially pronounced for violations on voting rights: In the US support for in-party transgressions even increases from 6.8% to 23.8%, representing more than a threefold rise. A potential explanation is that citizens regard voting rights as a cornerstone of democracy, making violations in this domain particularly salient (Carey et al. 2019; Ferrer et al. 2025). Moreover, elections represent a zero-sum game, where any advantage gained by one side directly comes at the expense of the other.

The results for freedom of the press, however, are less consistent. Though we again document a significantly higher willingness to engage in undemocratic acts among the treatment group in the US, the effect sizes are a bit smaller. Moreover, the effects do not reach significance in England. One possible explanation for the weaker reciprocal response on this issue is that violations of freedom of the press are perceived as less severe. Research shows that citizens view freedom of the press as a less central democratic principle compared to voting or protest rights (Carey et al. 2019). Consistent with this interpretation, we find the highest baseline support for undemocratic behavior in the control group on this topic in both countries.

Robustness checks and scope conditions

We conduct a range of additional tests to assess the robustness and scope of our model. First, we preregistered a second hypothesis that affective polarization could amplify tendencies to reciprocate transgressions. For reasons of space constraints we present an elaborate theory for this hypothesis as well as the detailed results in SI E. As illustrated in Figure 2, we document a statistically significant *direct* effect of affective polarization on respondents' endorsement of

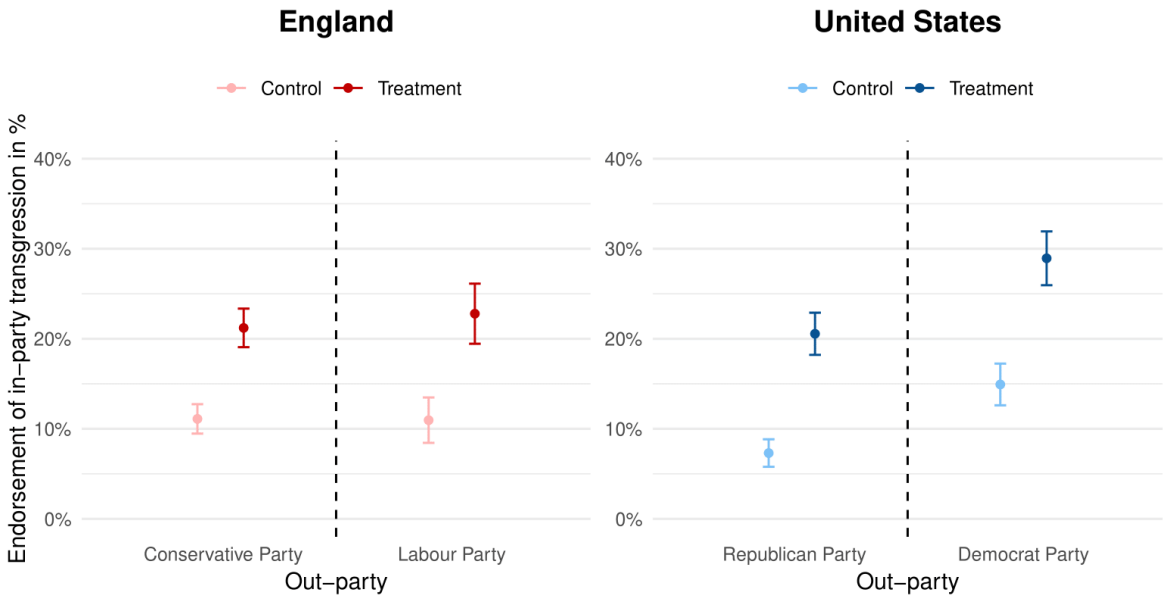
in-party transgressions (RRR = 1.009, p = 0.036 in England and RRR = 1.009, p < 0.001 in the US). Substantively, this means that affectively polarized citizens are somewhat more supportive of in-party undemocratic measures, no matter whether they are in the control or treatment group. We, however, find no significant *interaction* effect between affective polarization and the treatment as visualized by the parallel slopes. The lack of an interaction effect indicates that tendencies to reciprocate democratic transgressions are not stronger among more affectively polarized citizens. Further robustness checks accounting for non-linearity (Janssen and Turkenburg 2025), separating in- and out-party affect, relying on horizontal social distance measures (England only), employing a mean-distance operationalization of affective polarization, using a dyadic measure of affective polarization, relying on a measure of partisan strength (US only), as well as running OLS regressions excluding 'Don't know' responses yield similar results.



Fg 2. Support for (reciprocal) transgressions by affective polarization.

Note: Error bars present 95% CIs. N = 3,983 in England and N = 4,052 in the US. Model estimates are reported in SI Table E1. Figures disaggregated by transgression type are available in the extended SI Figure E4.
Alt text: Two side-by-side line plots, for England and the US, showing percentage endorsement of in-party transgression rising with affective polarization for both a lighter control line and a darker, higher treatment line, with roughly parallel slopes.

Second, we demonstrate in Figure 3 that reciprocity functions independently of who respondents select as the out-party. Opponents of the Labour and Conservative Party, as well as opponents of the Democratic and Republican Party are equally prone to reciprocate transgressions. However, the baseline support levels for undemocratic measures in the control group are considerably higher among opponents of the Democratic Party in the US.



Fg 3. Support for (reciprocal) transgressions by out-party.

Note: Error bars present 95% CIs. N = 4,031 in England and N = 4,069 in the US. Model estimates are reported in SI Table F1. Figures disaggregated by transgression type are available in the extended SI Figure F1.
Alt text: Two side-by-side dot plots with error bars, for England and the US, plotting percentage endorsement of in-party transgression by out-party: Conservative and Labour in England, Republican and Democratic in the United States. Each out-party shows a lighter control estimate and a higher darker treatment estimate.

Third, we examine whether citizens not only mirror out-party violations but also support *escalated* responses. That is, undemocratic acts by their own party that exceed the severity of the opponent's initial transgression. For this, respondents rated their approval of an escalated undemocratic act on an 11-point scale (0–10) (See SI G for more details on the item wording and results). While baseline support for such escalated behavior is again low - 36.9% of English and 38.6% of American respondents strongly disapprove – we nonetheless observe significant positive treatment effects as shown in SI G. This suggests that exposure to a political

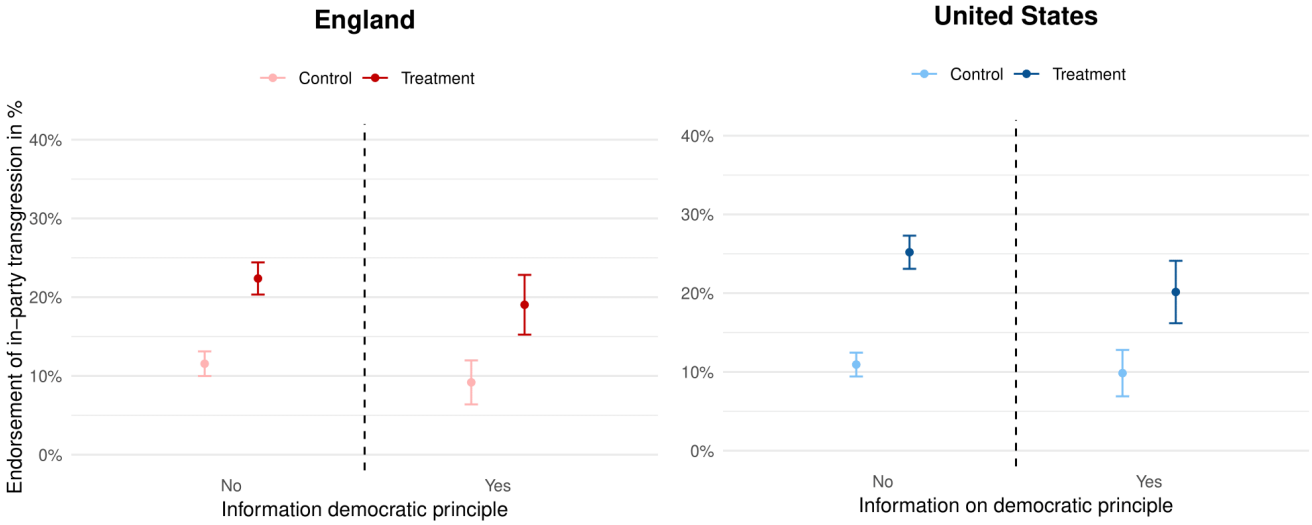
opponent's democratic violation not only increases support for direct reciprocation but can also push some citizens toward endorsing *more extreme* violations by their own party.

Fourth, we investigate whether reciprocity also holds for a different outcome variable that taps into mechanisms of electoral accountability. We find that treated respondents are more willing to vote for an undemocratic in-party candidate when the opposing party subverts democracy first, hence corroborating the findings from our main analysis (SI Table H2).

Lastly, we test whether reciprocity persists even when citizens are made explicitly aware that it goes against core democratic principles. Prior research indicates that citizens have varying understandings of democracy and frequently fail to accurately identify the actions of politicians as undemocratic (Krishnarajan 2023; Wunsch et al. 2025). Consequently, it could be argued that citizens only reciprocate the behavior of the opponent because they are unaware that these acts constitute a breach of democratic principles. Hence, we run a pre-registered analysis among a random subset of the sample (i.e., 20%) who are shown information about the importance of either protesting, voting, or freedom of the press prior to treatment-allocation (vignettes available in SI I). The democratic information provided to respondents always matches their assigned transgression (e.g., those assigned to the transgression of voting rights receive information specifically about the importance of voting). Making democratic principles explicit can have a dual effect: it may heighten citizens' democratic awareness and make them more inclined to uphold democracy, but it may also amplify perceptions of wrongdoing and the desire to reciprocate by clearly stating that the opponent's actions are undemocratic.

The results of the analysis are presented in Figure 4 (see SI I for more details). The baseline endorsement of undemocratic behavior by the own party is somewhat lower when respondents are first informed about the democratic principle in their country (i.e., 9.2% in England and 10.3% in the US), which is also reflected in the statistically significant and negative direct effect of this additional vignette (RRR = 0.785 in England, and RRR = 0.775 in the US). We, however, find no indication that the treatment effects are significantly lower when

respondents are made explicitly aware of the democratic principle. If anything, in England, we document that the treatment effects become slightly stronger with a relative risk ratio of 2.45 as compared to 2.13 for the aggregated results. These findings further underline citizens' willingness to reciprocate democratic transgressions, even when they are told about the importance of upholding the principle for democracy. So, though informing respondents about the democratic principles in their country slightly decreases their baseline support for undemocratic behavior, it does not seem to affect their tendency to reciprocate.



Fg 4. Support for (reciprocal) transgressions by exposure to democracy-information.

Note: Error bars present 95% CIs. Information group – N = 829 (England), N = 793 (US); No-information group – N = 3,202 (England), N = 3,276 (US). Model estimates are reported in SI Table I1. Figures disaggregated by transgression type are available in the extended SI Figure I1.
Alt text: Two side-by-side dot plots with error bars, for England and the US, plotting percentage endorsement of in-party transgression by whether respondents received information on the democratic principle, No or Yes.

Exploratory Analyses: Why do citizens reciprocate transgressions?

What drives citizens to engage in reciprocal democratic transgressions? Theoretically, we identified various potential motivations: a need to re-establish fairness within democracy, a desire to take revenge, or a process of normalization.[6] To empirically study these motivations,

[6] See SI K for treatment effects on fairness, revenge, and normalization using closed-ended questions.

we included open-ended questions in our survey, allowing respondents to freely articulate their justifications without the limitations imposed by closed-ended response options. In total, 907 out of 930 respondents in the treatment group who endorsed reciprocal undemocratic actions provided a written justification (England N = 424; US N = 483). As preregistered, we code these open answers using a deductive scheme implemented with ChatGPT-4 (prompt available in SI J). The model was prompted to assign each open answer to the best-fitting category: Fairness, revenge, normalization, or other. ChatGPT has been shown to perform well on text coding tasks, even outperforming crowd workers (Gilardi et al. 2023). Furthermore, we complement this analysis with qualitative abductive coding, the results of which are available in SI J and informed the development of the deductive coding scheme.

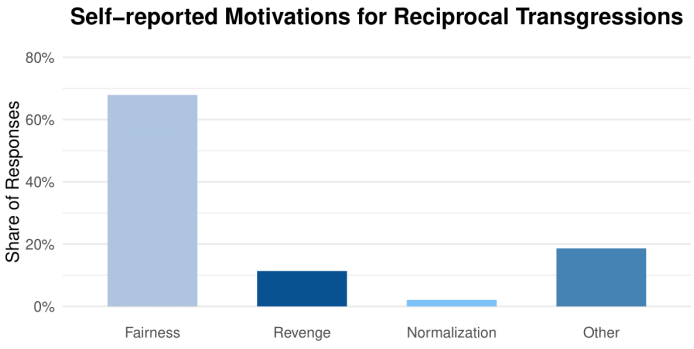
Turning to the findings, the distribution of the categories is presented in Figure 5. The most frequently cited rationale for supporting reciprocal democratic transgressions is fairness, accounting for 68% of all responses. Respondents in this category describe reciprocity as a symmetrical and justified response to the initial out-party violation. As one respondent put it: *"I feel like if the Democrats are doing it, then it is only fair for our party to do the same thing."* Relatedly, many in this category view reciprocal acts as a corrective mechanism aimed at restoring balance in the political sphere and ensuring equal treatment across parties. For example, one respondent explained: *"In the spirit of fairness and democracy, there should not be rules for one party and not the other. If Democrats restrict certain news outlets from attending, then Republicans should be allowed the same option."* General appeals to reciprocity, such as phrases like *"tit for tat",* were also classified under this category. Further manual coding shows that fairness overwhelmingly remains the largest category, even when these abstract notions of reciprocity are excluded (see SI J for more details).

Revenge-related motivations are documented in 11% of the open answers. These responses voice a desire to punish the opponent for their undemocratic behavior through retaliation or reflect a general animosity towards the opposing party. For example, one

respondent remarked *"This is a retaliation to what they intend doing to us, so we let them have a taste of their own medicine"*. Another wrote "*Republicans are evil and they work against the good of the people that vote for them. They are extremely racist and very unfair. Therefore, it's time for someone to treat them unfair!"*.

Notably, we do not document clear evidence of the theorized normalization process, with only 2% of the answers falling into this category. This may reflect a limitation of open answers, as certain categories may be underreported due to social desirability or because they are not easily observable to respondents. Indeed, normalization is often subconscious in nature (Bicchieri 2017), making it less likely to be explicitly articulated by respondents.

Lastly, we identify a residual "Other" category, which comprises approximately 19% of responses. This group includes a range of answers, some of which did not meaningfully engage with the question (e.g., gibberish or responses like "Don't know"). To deepen our understanding of the motivations captured in this category and to remain open to rationales beyond our initial theoretical framework, we complement the deductive automated coding with a qualitative abductive analysis. While the overarching patterns are consistent – particularly the dominance of fairness-based justifications – the abductive approach reveals additional motivational themes (e.g., deterrence, a desire to win elections) (Results are presented in SI J).



Fg 5. Self-reported motivations for reciprocal democratic transgressions.
Alt text: Bar chart of the share of open-ended responses across four motivation categories, with fairness by far the largest, followed by other and revenge, and normalization the smallest.

Discussion and Conclusion

This study has highlighted the interactive nature of citizens' democratic attitudes by introducing and testing the concept of reciprocity in the context of democratic transgressions. While previous research has largely focused on citizens' one-sided motivations in explaining support for undemocratic measures, our argument shifts the focus to the underexplored relational context of politics. By leveraging survey experiments in England and the US, we show that citizens' support for undemocratic measures is contingent on the conduct of other parties. Specifically, our study yields four key findings.

First, when citizens are exposed to democratic violations of political opponents, they become twice as likely to endorse undemocratic measures by their own party in response. In other words, we find evidence that citizens reciprocate democratic defections. The strong driving force of reciprocity in citizens' support for democratic violations suggests that (perceived) undemocratic elite behavior – even if initially condemned by citizens – can initiate a vicious cycle driven by reciprocal actions. Where prior research has already established that citizens are more likely to endorse democratic violations when they expect opponents will do the same (Braley et al. 2023; Pasek et al. 2022), our results demonstrate that such support also emerges as a direct reaction to violations that have already taken place. This has important implications for interventions aimed at improving citizens' democratic commitments. Scholars have argued that correcting biased beliefs about opponents' willingness to subvert democracy can reduce support for undemocratic practices (Braley et al. 2023; Voelkel et al. 2024), though the robustness of such interventions has been questioned (Dias et al. 2024; Druckman 2023). Our findings suggest a further boundary condition: in contexts where violations are occurring, misperception correction may prove insufficient on its own, as citizens are not only acting on biased beliefs about opponents' intentions but also reacting to actual undemocratic events.

It is worth noting, however, that despite the strong tendency to reciprocate transgressions, the vast majority of citizens oppose violations of democratic principles. This

broad rejection of undemocratic behavior occurs even when citizens are provoked by an out-party transgression. As such, our results also highlight that most citizens are committed to democratic principles: When the opposing party subverts democracy, the majority still prefers their party to maintain democratic integrity rather than to descend to reciprocal actions. Although support for undemocratic actions tends to be higher in studies involving trade-offs between democracy and partisan interests (e.g., Graham and Svolik 2020), our findings align with prior work which shows that most citizens reject democratic violations even amid high levels of partisan conflict (Holliday et al. 2024; Westwood et al. 2022).

Second, we find that the tendency to reciprocate democratic transgressions is independent of partisan affiliation and affective polarization. These findings partly resonate with recent work – which challenges the notion that affective polarization poses a fundamental threat to democracies (Broockman et al. 2023; Voelkel et al. 2024) – though we do document that baseline endorsement of undemocratic behavior is somewhat higher among polarized citizens. As such, our results paint a more nuanced picture, in which anti-democratic attitudes are not entirely independent of affective polarization, but its effects do not extend to the reciprocation of transgressions. The absence of a significant moderating effect suggests that reciprocity is a more universal impulse, one that emerges broadly across the electorate and independently of partisan animosity. This distinguishes our reciprocity account from existing work on interconnected democratic commitments, where biased beliefs about opponents' willingness to violate democracy are concentrated among strong partisans (Pasek et al. 2022).

Third, citizens do not reciprocate transgressions due to a lack of awareness about democracy: tendencies to reciprocate transgressions are strong, even when citizens are explicitly informed about the importance of a democratic principle in their country. Since reciprocation tendencies can thus not be prevented by educating citizens about the relevance of democratic principles, developing successful strategies to halt a potential spiral of reciprocal transgressions proves to be complex.

Lastly, our open question analysis provides insights into the self-reported justifications of citizens to endorse democratic transgressions. Contrary to the dominant view in the literature that some citizens somewhat selfishly prioritize their own political gains over the principles of democracy, we find that many citizens report being caught in a trade-off between competing moral principles: Commitment to democratic norms on the one hand, and universal principles of fairness on the other hand. From their perspective, mirroring the out-party violation provides an opportunity to restore the balance in politics and protect democracy on a broader scale. This observation speaks to a recent study by Krishnarajan (2023), who shows that citizens tend to rationalize undemocratic behavior as serving higher democratic goals. It also reveals a fundamental insight into the principles that citizens adhere to in politics. Though these citizens may not meet the ideal standard of principled democrats, many act from deeply held beliefs about fairness and reciprocity. They are thus 'doing the wrong thing for the right reasons': while their response can further undermine democratic rules, they do so by a conviction that reciprocation is the right and just response, not out of a rejection of democracy.

Turning to the normative implications, the democratic ambiguity of negative reciprocity in politics needs to be acknowledged. Though the desire to reciprocate may come from good intentions like fairness and maintaining a level playing field, reciprocating undemocratic behavior is not without risk. Our results indicate that citizens not only endorse responses in kind, but are willing to support escalated undemocratic reactions (SI G), suggesting that negative reciprocity may set in motion a self-reinforcing cycle of violations. Indeed, scholars have previously warned that reciprocity can "threaten the institutional foundations of democracy" (Schedler 2021, p. 258) and result in a "death spiral" of undemocratic behavior (Braley et al. 2023, p. 1283). At the same time, however, doing nothing in response to democratic transgressions risks granting a free pass to the transgressor. Reciprocation may also serve as a credible signal to political opponents that democratic violations will not go unanswered, potentially deterring further democratic subversion (Markovits 2026). Indeed,

game-theoretical work has shown that reciprocity can foster cooperative behavior (Güth 1995), implying that under certain conditions it may function as a stabilizing force. As such, determining what constitutes the best – and ultimately the most democracy-preserving – response represents a fundamental normative and strategic dilemma, one that political theorists have likewise debated (Bateman 2025; Malkopoulou 2026). One way out of this dilemma, as Schedler (2021) argues, lies in resistance through accountability, ostracism, mild forms of retaliation, or civil disobedience. This means that behavior aimed at inhibiting and punishing the perpetrator in the interest of democratic preservation is normatively desirable. Behavior aimed at the continued dismantling of democratic principles, such as the right to vote and protest or the freedom of the press, is not. Consequently, we consider reciprocal transgression in our study as normatively problematic, although both theoretically and empirically, citizens may have valid reasons to endorse them.

Our study also has limitations, which we encourage future research to address. The experimental design, while strong in internal validity, relies on hypothetical scenarios and therefore cannot capture all the nuances of real-world political interactions. Future studies using more naturalistic or field-experimental designs would therefore be valuable for assessing the external validity of these findings, particularly regarding how politicians' rhetoric and competing information environments shape citizens' willingness to reciprocate (see Druckman 2023). Prior research has established that elite discourse around undemocratic behavior can influence the public's perceptions (Aytaç 2026). As such, elites who emphasize the need for reciprocity and fairness may further heighten reciprocal support for undemocratic actions among their supporters. Another limitation of our study concerns the geographic scope: The focus on England and the US – both democracies with majoritarian systems – limits the generalizability of the findings to other political contexts with different party structures.

With regards to the experimental design, our study focuses specifically on tit-for-tat dynamics in response to 'targeted' democratic transgressions – cases where the out-party

directly violates democratic norms at the expense of the respondents' preferred party. While this offers a strong test case for reciprocity, it remains unclear whether similar dynamics would emerge in response to non-targeted violations, such as those affecting third parties or broader democratic institutions. In addition, our design does not allow us to disentangle whether citizens' reciprocal responses are uniquely driven by democratic violations, or whether they might also be provoked by general disliked out-party acts (such as undesirable – yet procedurally democratic – policies initiated by opponents). Relatedly, our dependent variable operationalizes reciprocity as a choice between retaliation and restraint. While we complement this measure with candidate-choice items and a scale capturing support for escalated transgressions, the design may nevertheless overlook alternative ways in which citizens may respond to democratic violations. Future research could therefore explore whether citizens also support more institutional or democracy-reinforcing responses to democratic transgressions, such as challenging these actions through courts or other democratic procedures.

Despite these limitations, our results demonstrate the far-reaching impact of negative reciprocity on human behavior, highlighting how its effects extend to citizens' democratic commitments. In doing so, we make a crucial contribution to the literature by stressing the interdependent nature of democratic attitudes and by providing novel insights into citizens' self-reported need for fairness when confronted with democratic transgressions by out-party elites. Importantly, our results call attention to the need for a more dynamic approach to studying democratic support – one that acknowledges the fundamental interactive nature of politics and human behavior.

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Supplementary Information

'When they go low, we kick them': The reciprocal nature of citizens' support for democratic transgressions

Lisa Janssen, Hannah Werner, & Anna Kern

A. Pre-registration....1
B. Sample characteristics....1
C. Survey design....4
D. Results regression models....5
E. Affective polarization....6
F. Reciprocal transgressions & party affiliation....12
G. Beyond tit-for-tat: Supporting disproportionate transgressions in response....12
H. Voting for undemocratic candidates....14
I. Do citizens reciprocate democratic transgressions knowingly?....14
J. Open Answer analysis....15
K. Closed-ended questions: Motivations to reciprocate transgressions....20
L. Democratic consistency: Reciprocating transgressions while supporting democracy?...21
M. Threat perceptions of the political opponent....22
N. Reciprocation on a different level of democracy....23
O. Real-life examples of vignettes and realism....24

A. Pre-registration

We pre-registered all key aspects of this study: The main argument, hypotheses, experimental design, full questionnaire, data collection procedures, measurement of all variables, and estimation methods. The time-stamped pre-registration can be consulted via OSF:

- England: https://osf.io/hvpqk/overview
- US: https://osf.io/mr9hs/overview

Deviations from pre-registration

Although we followed our pre-registrations on virtually all aspects, we made three minor changes:

I. We slightly changed the wording in our hypotheses by putting the word 'reciprocal' in between brackets. We had to make this change since 'reciprocal' transgressions are not logical for respondents in the control group: They are not presented with a previous act of a political opponent in vignettes, and therefore, their answer on the dependent variable is not 'reciprocal' by nature.

II. In our pre-registration of the survey in England, we did not specify what to do with missing values on the like/dislike measures of the different political parties. Within the survey, respondents are asked to indicate their feelings towards five different parties (i.e., Labour Party, Conservative Party, LibDem, Reform UK, & Green Party) using feeling-thermometers. Since a total of 503 respondents selected the 'Don't know' option for one or more of the political parties, we are unable to calculate their affective polarization scores based on all parties using the spread-measure of Wagner (2021). Hence, alternatively, for these specific respondents, we compute their affective polarization scores based on the ratings of the Labour Party and the Conservative Party. These two parties received the fewest 'Don't know'-responses and are the two largest parties in the UK, meaning that they carry the most weight in the calculation of affective polarization. In Supplementary Information E, we show that our results do not depend on how these 'don't know' responses are handled.

III. The pre-registered exploratory tests on citizens' threat perception of political opponents as well as their tendency to reciprocate on a different democratic principle were not presented in the main manuscript due to space constraints. Instead, the results can be found in supplementary information M & N.

B. Sample characteristics

Participants were recruited on a voluntary basis through Prolific's online survey panel. All respondents received fair compensation for their participation (i.e., 0.75 pounds for completing the survey in both England and the US with an estimated survey-time of 5 minutes). Before agreeing to participate, respondents were provided with a description of the study, guaranteed anonymity, and informed about data protection through an informed consent. Table B1 provides descriptive statistics. Whereas we used a quota sample based on education and gender in England, we relied on a politically representative sample with interlocked quotas in the US.

In addition, Table B2 compares our samples to the target populations on key sociodemographic variables. For England, population benchmarks are drawn from the 2021 Census provided by the Office for National Statistics; in the US, we rely on data from the US Census Bureau. The

English sample is representative in terms of gender, though individuals aged 25 to 54 are somewhat overrepresented. Because the education categories in our survey do not map cleanly onto those used in the 2021 Census, we cannot directly assess representativeness on education for England. In the U.S. sample, gender and age distributions closely match those of the electorate, although lower-educated respondents are slightly underrepresented – a common pattern in survey research.

Table B3 presents balance tests across treatment conditions. In England and the US, we find no statistically significant differences between the control and treatment groups, or between the experimental group who did and did not receive the additional democratic information vignette, on any of the pre-treatment sociodemographic or attitudinal covariates.

Table B1. Descriptive statistics

	England			United States		
	Mean	Std. Dev.	Range	Mean	Std. Dev.	Range
Dem. Satis.	2.637	1.097	1-5	2.916	1.161	1-5
Out-party						
Conservative	.702		0-1			
Labour	.298		0-1			
Republican				.557		0-1
Democrat				.443		0-1
Reciprocity						
Democratic	.731		0-1	.757		0-1
Undemocratic	.164		0-1	.175		0-1
Don't know	.105		0-1	.068		0-1
AP	23.848	11.466	0-50	49.785	30.632	0-100
In-party affect	71.524	18.500	0-100	68.503	23.911	0-100
Out-party affect	16.847	19.195	0-100	19.487	20.544	0-100
Importance protests	4.189	.954	1-5	4.500	.789	1-5
Not at all important	.012		0-1	.007		0-1
Hardly	.044		0-1	.017		0-1
Moderately	.175		0-1	.092		0-1
Very	.282		0-1	.237		0-1
Extremely important	.487		0-1	.647		0-1
Importance vote	4.733	.598	0-5	4.789	.544	0-5
Not at all important	.004		0-1	.003		0-1
Hardly	.007		0-1	.006		0-1
Moderately	.038		0-1	.029		0-1
Very	.156		0-1	.124		0-1
Extremely important	.795		0-1	.839		0-1
Importance press	4.286	.921	1-5	4.444	.840	1-5
Not at all important	.010		0-1	.008		0-1
Hardly	.037		0-1	.022		0-1
Moderately	.149		0-1	.116		0-1
Very	.264		0-1	.227		0-1
Extremely important	.540		0-1	.628		0-1

Note: N = 4,040 in England and N = 4,084 in the US.

Table B2. Sociodemographic statistics

	England		United States	
	Target	Sample	Target	Sample
Age				
18-24	10.5%	7.8%	11.7%	11.6%
25-39	25.5%	37.8%	25.9%	26.5%
40-54	24.8%	30.2%	23.7%	22.9%
55+	39.2%	24.3%	38.6%	38.9%
Gender				
Female	51%	51.1%	51%	51.0%
Male	49%	48.9%	49%	49.0%
Education				
No formal qual.		2.0%	9.3%	0.7%
Secondary (UK only)		26.0%		
High school		17.0%	28.7%	12.8%
Some college (US only)			15.9%	20.0%
Technical		5.0%	4.4%	3.5%
Associate (US only)			6.0%	11.0%
Bachelors		36.0%	22.4%	34.5%
Masters		11.9%	10.1%	14.0%
Professional (US only)			1.2%	1.7%
Doctorate		2.0%	2.0%	1.8%

Note: without excluding citizens below 18, the percentages of age groups amount to 8.3% (18-24), 20.2% (25-39), 19.6% (45-64), and 31.0% (55+) in England and 9.2% (18-24), 20.4% (25-39), 18.7% (40-54), and 30.4% (55+) in the US.

Table B3. Balance test across treatment conditions

	England						United States					
	Cont mean	Treat mean	T-test p	No prime mean	Yes prime mean	T-test p	Cont mean	Treat mean	T-test p	No prime mean	Yes prime mean	T-test p
Age	43.21 (14.01)	42.97 (13.87)	.57	42.97 (13.95)	43.57 (13.89)	.97	46.11 (16.00)	46.24 (16.01)	.80	46.31 (15.91)	45.61 (16.37)	.27
Sex	0.49 (0.50)	0.49 (0.50)	.97	0.48 (0.50)	0.50 (0.50)	.30	0.49 (0.50)	0.49 (0.50)	.65	0.49 (0.50)	0.49 (0.50)	.91
Education	3.90 (1.55)	3.92 (1.55)	.64	3.92 (1.55)	3.86 (1.53)	.27	4.94 (1.87)	4.86 (1.84)	.22	4.89 (1.85)	4.94 (1.85)	.47
Out-party												
Lab/Dem	0.29 (0.46)	0.30 (0.46)	.55	0.30 (0.46)	0.31 (0.46)	.57	0.45 (0.50)	0.44 (0.50)	.43	0.44 (0.50)	0.45 (0.50)	.79
Con/Rep	0.71 (0.46)	0.70 (0.46)	.55	0.70 (0.46)	0.69 (0.46)	.57	0.55 (0.50)	0.56 (0.50)	.43	0.56 (0.50)	0.55 (0.50)	.79
AP	24.07 (11.37)	23.62 (11.56)	.21	23.78 (11.43)	24.12 (11.60)	.44	49.91 (30.41)	49.63 (30.86)	.77	49.85 (30.85)	49.46 (29.74)	.75
Dem. satis	2.65 (1.08)	2.62 (1.11)	.37	2.64 (1.10)	2.64 (1.10)	.87	2.95 (1.15)	2.88 (1.17)	.06	2.92 (1.16)	2.90 (1.18)	.63
Recip.												
Dem	0.77 (0.42)	0.69 (0.46)	**.00**	0.72 (0.45)	0.76 (0.43)	**.02**	0.83 (0.37)	0.68 (0.43)	**.00**	0.75 (0.43)	0.79 (0.40)	**.00**
Undem	0.11 (0.31)	0.22 (0.41)	**.00**	0.17 (0.38)	0.14 (0.35)	**.04**	0.11 (0.31)	0.24 (0.43)	**.00**	0.18 (0.38)	0.15 (0.36)	**.04**
Don't kn.	0.12 (0.32)	0.09 (0.29)	**.00**	0.11 (0.31)	0.10 (0.30)	**.34**	0.06 (0.23)	0.08 (0.27)	**.02**	0.07 (0.26)	0.06 (0.23)	**.12**

Note: Means are reported with standard deviations in parentheses. P-values are derived from two-sided independent samples t-tests comparing control vs. treatment and no prime vs. yes prime conditions. Bold p-values indicate statistical significance at the $p < .05$ level.

C. Survey design

Table C1 presents the vignettes used to inform respondents about the democratic principle in their country (i.e., presented to a random 20% of the sample), the treatment vignettes, and the corresponding dependent variables (i.e., endorsement of undemocratic behavior by the respondent's own party and escalation). The full questionnaire is available in the replication package.

Table C1. Overview vignettes & dependent variables per democratic principle

	Protests	Voting rights	Freedom of the press
Democratic vignette	In the [UK/US], [the freedom of assembly permits people to join and organize protests/the First Amendment protects your right to assemble and express your views through protest]. Protests are public gatherings where people come together to show their support or disagreement with a political issue that they find important. It is a way for individuals and groups to speak up about issues they care about.	In the [UK/US], every eligible citizen has the right to vote in general elections. Voting is the act of expressing one's political preferences by casting a ballot on election day. It provides citizens with an opportunity to have a say in the governance of the country.	In the [UK, there is/US, the First Amendment ensures] freedom of the press. This means that journalists and media outlets can report news and express their opinions without restrictions or interference from the government. This ensures that all citizens have access to diverse viewpoints and uncensored information.
Treatment vignettes	Imagine the following: Politicians from [out-party] have taken action to prohibit political protests by supporters of [in-party]. Politicians from [in-party] are now considering how they should respond to this act.	Imagine the following: Politicians from [out-party] have taken action to pass a law that would make it more difficult for supporters of [in-party] to cast their vote during the next election. Politicians from [in-party] are now deliberating how they should respond to this act.	Imagine the following: Politicians from [out-party] have taken action to prohibit critical [right/left-leaning] news outlets, including {The Daily Telegraph/The Guardian OR Fox News/CNN], from attending their press meetings. Politicians from [in-party] are now considering how they should respond to this act.
Dependent variable	Amongst politicians of [in-party], there is a discussion about how they should handle protests in the [UK/US]. What would you like to see them do? I) Politicians from [in-party] should take action to prohibit political protests by supporters of [out-party]. II) Politicians from [in-party] should not take action to prohibit protests by supporters of [out-party]. III) Don't know	Amongst politicians of [in-party], there is a discussion about how they should handle voting rules in the [UK/US]. What would you like to see them do? I) Politicians from [in-party] should take action to prohibit political protests by supporters of [out-party]. II) Politicians from [in-party] should not take action to pass a law that would make it more difficult for supporters of [out-party] to cast their vote during the next election. III) Don't know	Amongst politicians of [in-party], there is a discussion about how they should handle critical media in their press meetings. What would you like to see them do? I) Politicians from [in-party] should take action to prohibit critical [right/left-leaning] news outlets, including [The Daily Telegraph/The Guardian OR Fox News/CNN], from attending their press meetings. II) Politicians from [in-party] should not take action to prohibit critical [right/left-leaning] news outlets, including [The Daily Telegraph/The Guardian OR Fox News/CNN], from attending their press meetings. III) Don't know

D. Results regression models

Table D1 presents the multinomial regression models, which reveal strong and highly significant treatment effects on respondents' support for reciprocal transgressions. Specifically, among those in the treatment group, the relative risk of endorsing an undemocratic response (as opposed to rejecting one) increases by a factor of 2.13 in England and 2.86 in the US.

The multinomial regression models also reveal some treatment effects on "don't know" responses. Before interpreting these patterns, it is important to note that only a small share of respondents selected "don't know": 10.54% in England and 6.78% in the US (see SI B, Table B1). In England, the treatment marginally reduces 'don't know' responses, suggesting less uncertainty after exposure to out-party transgressions. Yet, this effect is driven solely by the press-freedom vignette. In the US, the treatment modestly increases 'don't know' responses, but only in the voting-rights condition. Importantly, these shifts are small and inconsistent across countries and vignettes, indicating that the treatment does not systematically inflate or depress "don't know" responses in a way that would bias our key results.

Figure D1 replicates Figure 1 from the manuscript using the full sample, including respondents assigned to the additional democracy-information treatment. The results confirm that the substantive conclusions remain unchanged regardless of the sample used, demonstrating the robustness of our findings. Table D2 further corroborates our main results using OLS models that exclude respondents who selected "don't know." We also run additional robustness checks that recode "don't know" respondents either as reciprocators or as non-reciprocators. Across all specifications, the treatment effect remains strong and statistically significant, demonstrating that our results are not sensitive to how "don't know" responses are handled. For reasons of space constraints, these latter robustness checks are provided in the replication materials rather than in the SI.

Table D1. Support for (reciprocal) transgressions, Multinomial logistic regressions

	England				US			
	Combined	Protest	Vote	Press	Combined	Protest	Vote	Press
Undemocratic response								
Treatment	2.128***	2.338***	3.450***	1.174	2.859***	3.581***	4.724***	1.555**
	(0.212)	(0.379)	(0.642)	(0.210)	(0.281)	(0.594)	(0.940)	(0.250)
Don't know response								
Treatment	0.751*	0.827	1.230	0.440***	1.607***	1.466	3.012***	0.945
	(0.088)	(0.162)	(0.264)	(0.091)	(0.223)	(0.357)	(0.754)	(0.226)
Observations	3202	1068	1067	1067	3276	1093	1092	1091

Note: Exponentiated coefficients (Relative Risk Ratios); Standard errors in parentheses.
* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table D2. Support for (reciprocal) transgressions, OLS regressions (excluding don't know responses)

	England				US			
	Combined	Protest	Vote	Press	Combined	Protest	Vote	Press
Treatment	0.113***	0.146***	0.171***	0.021	0.157***	0.207***	0.194***	0.069**
	(0.015)	(0.027)	(0.024)	(0.024)	(0.014)	(0.025)	(0.023)	(0.025)
Constant	0.132***	0.156***	0.095***	0.149***	0.117***	0.119***	0.071***	0.161***
	(0.010)	(0.019)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.010)	(0.018)	(0.016)	(0.018)
Observations	2857	943	969	945	3044	1019	1011	1014

Note: Standard errors in parentheses.
* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

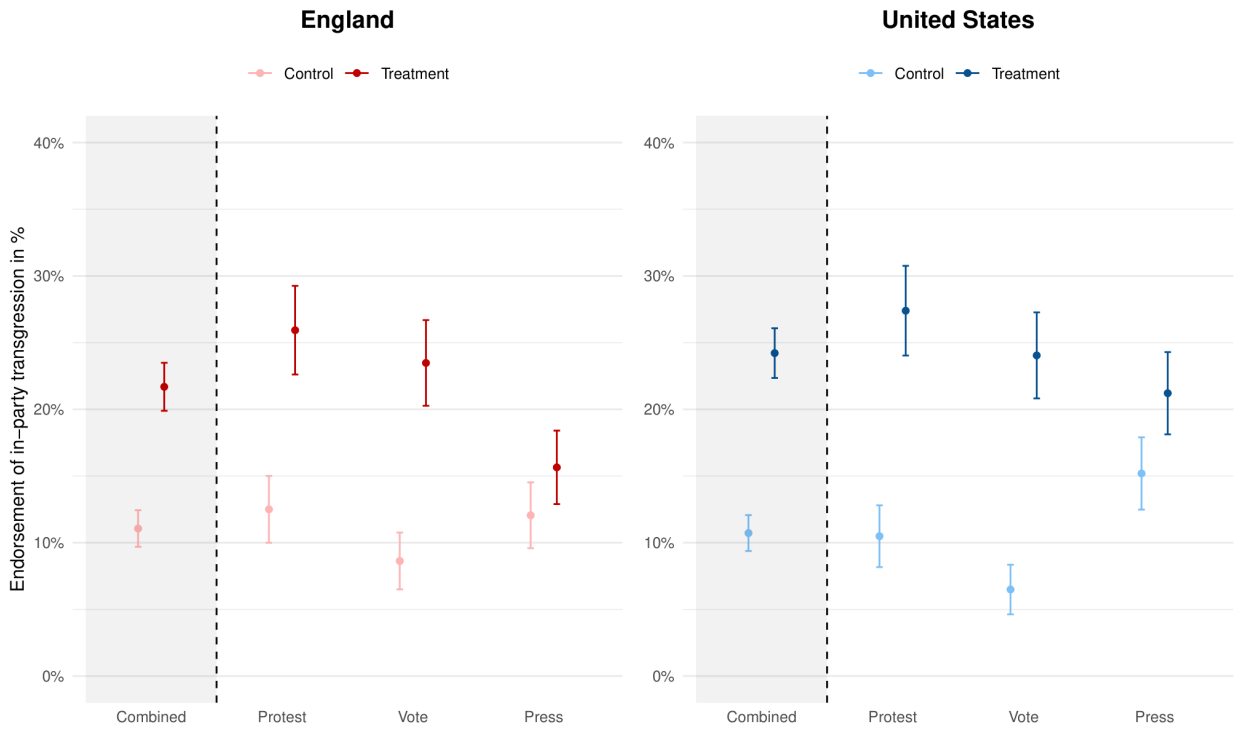


Figure D1. Percentage of respondents who support (reciprocal) transgressions, full sample.
Note: Error bars present 95% CIs. For the combined results, N = 4,031 in England and N = 4,069 in the US.

E. Affective polarization

Are some citizens more prone to reciprocate democratic violations than others? We propose that affective polarization – the tendency to feel positively toward one's political in-group and negatively toward the out-group (Iyengar and Westwood 2015) – can condition how citizens respond to undemocratic behavior.

Numerous studies provide dystopian perspectives on the political consequences of affective polarization (see Broockman et al. 2023 for overview), suggesting it contributes to citizens' anti-democratic behavior and autocratization more broadly (McCoy et al. 2018; Orhan 2022). Specifically, scholars posit that strong partisan attachments and hostility towards the political opponent shift citizens' priorities, making partisan interests outweigh the importance of democracy (Carey et al. 2022; Graham and Svolik 2020). However, empirical evidence on the relationship between affective polarization and democratic support is mixed (e.g., Broockman et al. 2023; Eroglu et al. 2025; Janssen and Turkenburg 2025; Kingzette et al. 2021; Voelkel et al. 2023, 2024). We build on this debate by proposing a more targeted mechanism: affective polarization intensifies reciprocal responses to democratic violations.

Research in psychology suggests that strong in-group attachments and out-group hostility heighten reciprocity motives (Stenstrom et al. 2008; Bradfield and Aquino 1999). When perpetrators are disliked or viewed as part of an opposing group, people are more likely to respond with anger, desire for revenge, and harsher punishment (Yzerbyt et al. 2003). In contrast, perpetrators with socially desirable qualities tend to elicit more forgiving and lenient responses (Bradfield and Aquino 1999). These dynamics suggest that affective polarization can amplify revenge-related motivations to reciprocate. We, therefore, formulate the second

hypothesis: *The positive effect of exposure to a democratic transgression perpetrated by a political opponent on support for a (reciprocal) democratic transgression by the own party is stronger for citizens with higher levels of vertical affective polarization.*

To examine the impact of vertical affective polarization on the mechanism of reciprocity, we ask respondents to rate the different political parties on a feeling-thermometer with scores of 0 indicating cold and negative feelings and scores of 100 indicating warm and positive feelings. We use the spread-measure of Wagner (2021) to calculate citizens' affective polarization levels in England (ranging from 0 to 50), as this measure is suitable for multi-party contexts and recognizes that individuals may feel positively (or negatively) towards multiple parties simultaneously. In the US, affective polarization is calculated as the absolute difference in the thermometer ratings of the Democratic and Republican Party (ranging from 0 to 100). In line with the recommendations of Sheagley and Clifford (2025), we measure this moderating variable pre-treatment.

The results of standard linear interaction models are presented in Table E1 and Figure E1. Though we document a significant direct effect of affective polarization on respondents' endorsement of in-party transgressions, we do not document a significant interaction effect. Contrary to our expectations, this means that citizens are no more likely to reciprocate democratic transgressions as they are more affectively polarized.

We estimate several additional models to assess the robustness of our findings. First, we estimate OLS regression models (Table E2) to verify that our results are consistent across alternative model specifications. Second, Table E3 presents results using alternative measures of affective polarization, including versions that exclude "don't know" responses on feeling thermometers for small parties in England, as well as a dyadic measure capturing respondents' affect toward the specific in-party and out-party presented in the vignette. In addition, we report results of measures based on social distance, mean-distance operationalizations, and partisan strength. Third, in line with the recommendations of Janssen and Turkenburg (2025) and Hainmueller et al. (2015), we conduct various tests to check for non-linear dynamics in our interaction effect. Figure E2 illustrates that the relationships between the outcome, treatment, and affective polarization are well approximated by a linear fit, as shown in Linear Interaction Diagnostic plots. Figure E3 illustrates the conditional marginal effects using binning estimators, which relax the assumptions of linear interaction effects. Additional Wald tests indicate that the null hypothesis – that the linear interaction model and the bin model are statistically equivalent – cannot be rejected (England: $p = .175$, US: $p = .418$).

Notably, we observe small negative interaction effects in the multinomial models for in-party affect and partisan strength (the latter measured only in the US; see SI Tables E1 and E2 for details). Contrary to our expectations, these estimates suggest that US citizens with stronger in-party attachments are somewhat less inclined to reciprocate democratic transgressions. However, these patterns are not robust across alternative model specifications: The interaction effects are not statistically significant in the corresponding OLS models, and the direction of the effect even shifts to positive. Moreover, once we adjust the multinomial models for multiple testing, the interaction effect with in-party affect also loses significance. Given their instability across specifications and their sensitivity to correction procedures, we refrain from drawing any substantive conclusions from these results.

Table E1. Support for democratic transgression of the own party by treatment and affective polarization, multinomial

	England				United States			
	M1	M2	M3	M4	M1	M2	M3	M4
Undemocratic								
Treatment	2.219***	2.340***	2.371***	2.750*	2.823***	3.716***	2.941***	6.449***
	(0.201)	(0.515)	(0.285)	(1.141)	(0.253)	(0.721)	(0.362)	(2.245)
AP	1.009*	1.010			1.009***	1.012***		
	(0.004)	(0.006)			(0.001)	(0.003)		
Treatment*AP		0.998				0.995		
		(0.008)				(0.003)		
Out-party affect			1.001				1.001	
			(0.004)				(0.003)	
Treatment*Out-party affect			0.996				0.997	
			(0.005)				(0.004)	
In-party affect				1.013**				1.023***
				(0.004)				(0.004)
Treatment*In-party affect				0.997				0.989*
				(0.005)				(0.004)
Don't know								
Treatment	0.870	0.786	0.888	0.663	1.667***	1.882**	1.553*	1.753
	(0.094)	(0.180)	(0.130)	(0.245)	(0.214)	(0.449)	(0.275)	(0.644)
AP	0.978***	0.976***			0.999	1.000		
	(0.005)	(0.006)			(0.002)	(0.003)		
Treatment*AP		1.005				0.997		
		(0.010)				(0.004)		
Out-party affect			1.005				0.998	
			(0.004)				(0.005)	
Treatment*Out-party affect			0.999				1.004	
			(0.005)				(0.006)	
In-party affect				0.984***				0.998
				(0.003)				(0.004)
Treatment*In-party affect				1.004				0.999
				(0.005)				(0.005)
Observations	3983	3983	3988	3981	4052	4052	4053	4059

Note: Exponentiated coefficients (Relative Risk Ratios); Standard errors in parentheses.
* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table E2. Support for democratic transgression of the own party by treatment and affective polarization excluding don't know responses, OLS

	England			United States			
	M1	M2	M3	M1	M2	M3	M4
Treatment	0.107***	0.125***	0.086	0.140***	0.159***	0.135***	0.137***
	(0.030)	(0.017)	(0.052)	(0.024)	(0.017)	(0.038)	(0.031)
AP	0.001			0.001***			
	(0.001)			(0.000)			
Treatment*AP	0.000			0.000			
	(0.001)			(0.000)			
Out-party affect		0.000			0.000		
		(0.000)			(0.000)		
Treatment*Out-party affect		-0.001			-0.000		
		(0.001)			(0.001)		
In-party affect			0.001*			0.002***	
			(0.001)			(0.000)	

Treatment*In-party affect			0.000			0.000	
			(0.001)			(0.001)	
Partisan strength							0.044***
							(0.007)
Treatment*Partisan strength							0.004
							(0.010)
Constant	0.097***	0.122***	0.032	0.054**	0.112***	-0.015	-0.014
	(0.022)	(0.012)	(0.037)	(0.017)	(0.012)	(0.027)	(0.021)
Observations	3584	3589	3582	3783	3784	3788	3774

Note: Standard errors in parentheses.
* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

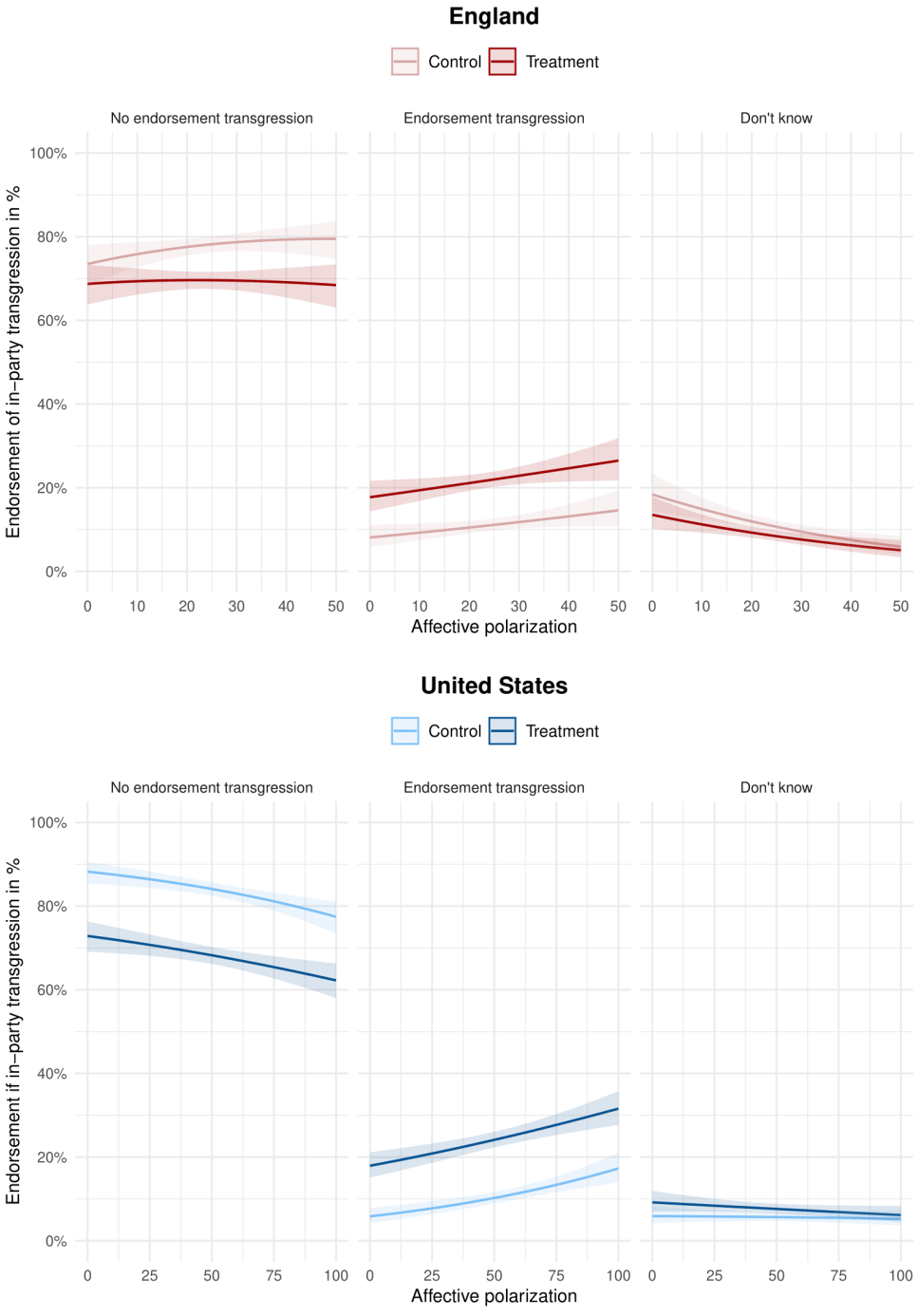


Figure E1. Support for (reciprocal) transgressions by affective polarization.
Note: Higher values denote a higher proportion of respondents who engage in an undemocratic response. Error bars present 95% CIs.

Table E3. Support for democratic transgression of the own party by treatment, affective polarization (excluding don't know responses), social distance, mean-distance affective polarization, dyadic affective polarization (based on the two parties presented in the respondent's vignette), and partisan strength.

	England				United States
	M1	M2	M3	M4	M1
Undemocratic					
Treatment	2.098**	2.588***		2.046**	5.582***
	(0.513)	(0.619)		(0.454)	(1.464)
Affective Polarization	1.009				
	(0.007)				
Treatment*Affective Polarization	1.003				
	(0.009)				
Social Distance		1.043			
		(0.061)			
Treatment*Social Distance		0.945			
		(0.069)			
Mean Distance			1.006		
			(0.004)		
Treatment*Mean Distance			1.004		
			(0.005)		
Dyadic AP				1.005	
				(0.003)	
Treatment*Dyadic AP				1.001	
				(0.003)	
Partisan Strength					1.572***
					(0.094)
Treatment*Partisan Strength					0.815**
					(0.060)
Don't know					
Treatment	0.856	0.937	0.978	0.791	1.315
	(0.222)	(0.240)	(0.259)	(0.175)	(0.397)
Affective Polarization	0.971***				
	(0.007)				
Treatment*Affective Polarization	1.004				
	(0.011)				
Social Distance		0.844**			
		(0.048)			
Treatment*Social Distance		0.972			
		(0.082)			
Mean Distance			0.986**		
			(0.004)		
Treatment*Mean Distance			0.999		
			(0.006)		
Dyadic AP				0.990***	
				(0.003)	
Treatment*Dyadic AP				1.002	
				(0.004)	
Partisan Strength					0.880
					(0.067)
Treatment*Partisan Strength					1.080
					(0.110)
Observations	3534	4010	3534	3976	4048

Note: Exponentiated coefficients (Relative Risk Ratios); Standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Figure E2. Linear Interaction Diagnostics plots with affective polarization

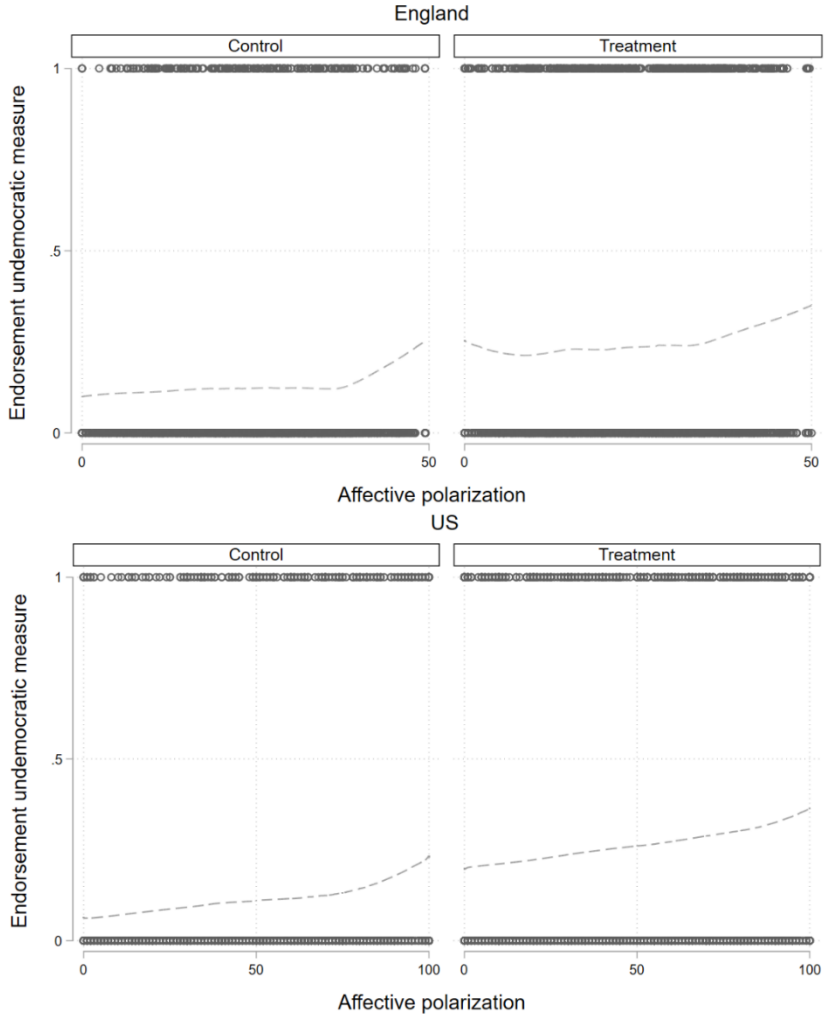
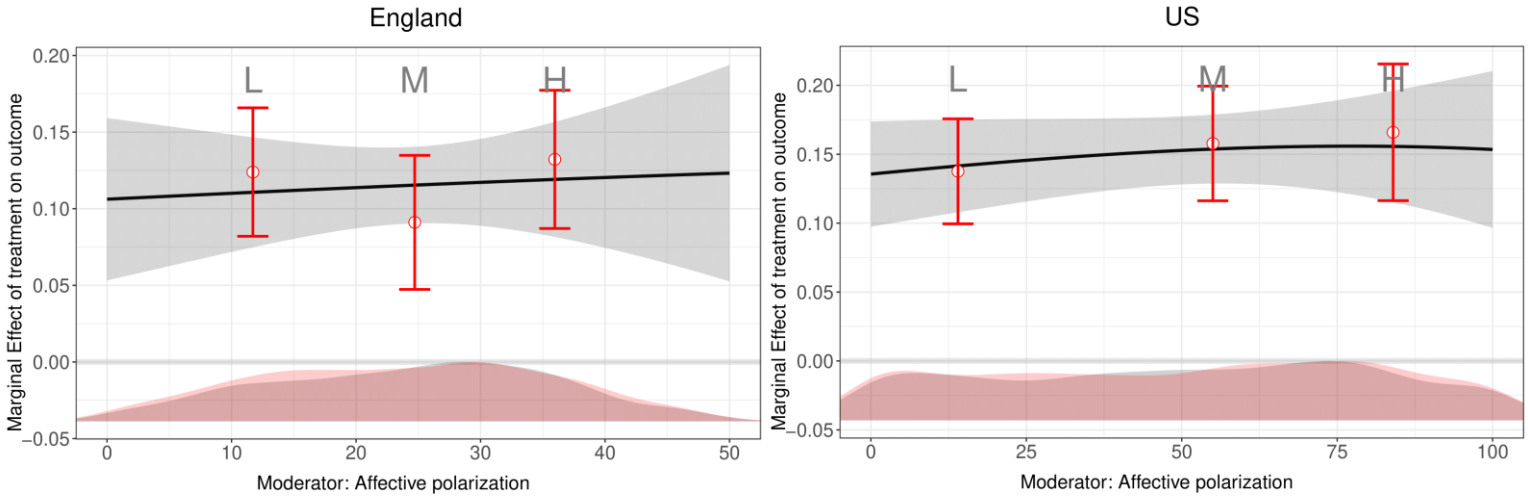


Figure E3. Marginal effects and the binning estimator (red dots) for the interaction between affective polarization and the treatment group



F. Reciprocal transgressions & party affiliation

Do baseline endorsement levels for in-party undemocratic measures differ in England between opponents of the Labour Party and the Conservative Party, or in the US between opponents of the Democratic Party and the Republican Party? Additionally, do tendencies to reciprocate transgressions vary depending on out-party? The results are presented in Table F1. In England, we do not document any notable difference between the different supporter-bases: the share of undemocratic responses across the Labour and Conservative Party are similar in both the control and treatment groups. This is also shown by the lack of a significant direct effect of out-party or interaction with the treatment. In the US, however, we do document that baseline endorsement levels of undemocratic measures are somewhat higher amongst opponents of the Democratic Party as compared to opponents of the Republican Party. Nonetheless, tendencies to reciprocate transgressions are similar across these parties, as is again evidenced by the insignificant interaction effect.

Table F1. Support for democratic transgression of the own party by treatment and out-party

	England		United States	
	M1	M2	M1	M2
Undemocratic				
Treatment	2.187***	2.388***	2.826***	2.421***
	(0.197)	(0.394)	(0.253)	(0.291)
Conservative	0.943	1.019		
	(0.089)	(0.160)		
Treatment*Conservative		0.882		
		(0.174)		
Republican			0.545***	0.435***
			(0.047)	(0.065)
Treatment*Republican				1.409
				(0.256)
Don't know				
Treatment	0.869	0.971	1.637***	1.521*
	(0.091)	(0.184)	(0.208)	(0.272)
Conservative	0.960	1.033		
	(0.109)	(0.158)		
Treatment*Conservative		0.852		
		(0.193)		
Republican			0.666**	0.620*
			(0.084)	(0.118)
Treatment*Republican				1.147
				(0.292)
Observations	4031	4031	4069	4069

Exponentiated coefficients (Relative Risk Ratios); Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

G. Beyond tit-for-tat: Supporting disproportionate transgressions in response

Citizens' responses to out-party transgressions can vary in their severity: people may opt for a proportional response that more or less mirrors the initial undemocratic behaviour of the political opponent, but they may also proceed to support a superlative and further escalation. In that case, citizens would endorse in-party democratic transgressions that escalate the severity of the initial violation by the political opponent. To examine the extent to which respondents support escalated transgressions, we ask them to rate their approval for a disproportionate

undemocratic response on a scale from 0 (Strongly disapprove) to 10 (Strongly approve). The escalated responses for the vignettes are shown in Table G1.

Again, the baseline support for escalated reciprocal transgressions is low: A large share of respondents – i.e., 36.9% in England and 38.6% in the US – report to strongly disapprove (i.e., a score of 0) of the more severe democratic transgression. This disapproval, however, is weaker among citizens who were presented with a democratic violation by a political opponent earlier: We document a significant positive effect of the treatment on the support for escalated reciprocal transgressions (See Table G2). Substantively, this means that citizens not only support reciprocation of transgressions that mirror the initial act of the opponent but also more extreme undemocratic acts by the own party that go beyond just leveling the democratic playing field. Given the skewed distribution of the dependent variable, we present Poisson regressions in Table G3 to further underscore the robustness of our findings.

Table G1. Question wording: Escalated transgressions

Variables	Survey item	Answers
Escalated transgressions	Within [in-party] there are also politicians who prefer a different course of action. On a scale from 0 to 10, can you rate to what extent you would approve of the following:	
Protests	Politicians from [in-party] should take action to prohibit political protests by supporters of [out-party]. On top of that, politicians from [in-party] should propose to order arrests of supporters of [out-party] that participate in unauthorised protests.	11-point scale ranging from (0) Strongly disapprove to (10) Strongly approve.
Vote	Politicians from [in-party] should take action to pass a law that would make it more difficult for supporters of [out-party] to cast their vote during the next election. On top of that, politicians from [in-party] should propose changes to voter registration procedures that create additional barriers for supporters of [out-party] to cast their vote.	
Press	Politicians from [in-party] should take action to prohibit critical [right/left]-leaning news outlets, including [The Daily Telegraph/The Guardian OR Fox News/CNN], from attending their press meetings. On top of that, politicians from [in-party] should propose to revoke the press credentials of journalists affiliated with these outlets to bar them from covering any official events.	

Table G2. Support for escalated transgressions, OLS regressions

	England				United States			
	Aggregated	Protest	Vote	Press	Aggregated	Protest	Vote	Press
Treatment	0.399***	0.569***	0.629***	-0.011	0.484***	0.425**	0.740***	0.285
	(0.081)	(0.144)	(0.131)	(0.142)	(0.091)	(0.159)	(0.152)	(0.160)
Constant	2.065***	2.024***	1.514***	2.675***	2.220***	2.343***	1.730***	2.588***
	(0.058)	(0.102)	(0.093)	(0.101)	(0.064)	(0.112)	(0.107)	(0.113)
Observations	3783	1258	1280	1245	3943	1317	1314	1312

Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table G3. Support for escalated transgressions, Poisson regressions

	England				United States			
	Aggregated	Protest	Vote	Press	Aggregated	Protest	Vote	Press
Treatment	0.177***	0.248***	0.348***	-0.004	0.197***	0.167***	0.356***	0.104**
	(0.022)	(0.037)	(0.042)	(0.035)	(0.020)	(0.035)	(0.039)	(0.033)
Constant	0.725***	0.705***	0.415***	0.984***	0.797***	0.851***	0.548***	0.951***
	(0.016)	(0.028)	(0.032)	(0.025)	(0.015)	(0.025)	(0.030)	(0.024)
Observations	3783	1258	1280	1245	3943	1317	1314	1312

Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

H. Voting for undemocratic candidates

In the US, we add an additional question to the survey and examine whether exposure to a transgression of a political opponent impacts citizens' willingness to vote for an in-party undemocratic political candidate. The wording of the survey questions and the results of the regression models are presented in Table H1 and Table H2, respectively.

Table H1. Question wording: Political accountability

Variables	Survey item	Answer options
Political Accountability	Now imagine that there is an election. How would you vote if you learned that…	101-point scale ranging from (0) Extremely likely to vote for [in-party] candidate to (100) Extremely likely to vote for [out-party] candidate.
Protest	the [in-party] candidate said that they want to take action to prohibit political protests by supporters of [out-party]?	
Vote	the [in-party] candidate said that they want to take action to pass a law that would make it more difficult for supporters of [out-party] to cast their vote during the next election?	
Press	the [in-party] candidate said that they want to take action to prohibit critical [right/left]-leaning news outlets, including [Fox News/CNN], from attending their press meetings?	

Table H2. Political accountability, OLS regressions

	United States Political Accountability
Treatment	3.937***
	(0.706)
Constant	63.596***
	(0.499)
Observations	4018

Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

I. Do citizens reciprocate democratic transgressions knowingly?

A random subset of 20% of the sample is shown an additional vignette (see Supplementary Information C for the exact wording) before being assigned to either the control or treatment groups. This additional vignette informs citizens about democratic principles in their country by providing information on either the right to protest, voting rights, or freedom of the press. Table I1 shows the treatment effects among this subset of the sample. Table I2 presents the direct effects of the democratic vignette, as well as its interaction with the treatment.

Table I1. Support for democratic transgression of the own party by treatment, subsample of respondents who received the additional informative vignette on democratic principles

	England				United States			
	Aggregated	Protest	Vote	Press	Aggregated	Protest	Vote	Press
Undemocratic								
Treatment	2.452***	2.713**	3.187**	1.663	2.390***	2.297*	6.217***	1.277
	(0.522)	(1.004)	(1.180)	(0.618)	(0.504)	(0.943)	(2.727)	(0.408)
Don't know								
Treatment	1.596	0.823	3.579**	1.479	1.683	2.527	2.110	0.910
	(0.383)	(0.346)	(1.659)	(0.600)	(0.533)	(1.406)	(1.238)	(0.488)
Observations	829	275	278	276	793	263	264	266

Exponentiated coefficients (Relative Risk Ratios); Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table I2. Support for democratic transgression of the own party by treatment and the additional informative vignette on democratic principles

	England		United States	
	M1	M2	M1	M2
Undemocratic				
Treatment	2.190***	2.128***	2.772***	2.859***
	(0.198)	(0.212)	(0.247)	(0.281)
Democratic information	0.785*	0.728	0.775*	0.872
	(0.088)	(0.137)	(0.087)	(0.163)
Treatment*Democratic information		1.152		0.836
		(0.271)		(0.195)
Don't know				
Treatment	0.869	0.751*	1.617***	1.607***
	(0.091)	(0.088)	(0.205)	(0.223)
Democratic information	0.850	0.588**	0.735	0.713
	(0.112)	(0.115)	(0.125)	(0.188)
Treatment*Democratic information		2.124**		1.047
		(0.567)		(0.362)
Observations	4031	4031	4069	4069

Exponentiated coefficients (Relative Risk Ratios); Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

J. Open Answer analysis

As preregistered, we analyze the open-ended survey responses using a deductive coding scheme implemented via ChatGPT-4. The goal of this analysis is to classify respondents' justifications for supporting reciprocal democratic transgressions into theoretically defined categories. Following our preregistration, we focus on three categories – fairness, revenge, and normalization – which were identified a priori based on our theoretical framework as the key motivations underlying reciprocal behavior. The full prompt used to guide the model's coding is shown in Table J1 below. Importantly, this few-shot prompt was directly informed by the qualitative abductive coding, which we explain in more detail below. This prompt instructed the model to assign each response to *one* of four mutually exclusive categories: Fairness, Revenge, Normalization, or None of the Above, based on predefined definitions and examples. The model was asked to return both the assigned category and a brief explanation for each classification decision. Responses were cleaned prior to submission to remove line breaks and missing data. A total of 907 valid responses were included in the final analysis. The full code is available in the replication materials. A random subset of 100 responses was manually double-coded to assess reliability, yielding substantial intercoder agreement (Cohen's Kappa = 0.72).

Table J1. Prompt ChatGPT-4

You are coding open-ended survey responses about citizens' support for their own party engaging in undemocratic behavior. Classify each response into only ONE of the following categories based on the best overall fit:
1. FAIRNESS: Supports reciprocity to restore fairness or balance and protect democracy. Examples: 'fair is fair', 'level playing field', 'counteract', 'justice', 'right', 'equal', 'prevent bias'.
2. REVENGE: Motivated by anger, desire to punish, or disapproval for the opposing party. Examples: 'payback', 'retaliate', 'make them suffer', 'attack', 'hate', 'The C party are a bunch of thieving toe rags'.

3. NORMALIZATION: Sees undemocratic actions as normal or common. Examples: 'normalize', 'common', 'This is how politics works'.
4. NONE OF THE ABOVE: The response does not clearly fit any of the categories above. This includes vague, unclear or off-topic statements with no clear motivation to reciprocate. Choose the ONE category that best matches the intent of the response. If a response could fit multiple categories, select the most appropriate one based on the dominant rationale.
Survey response: " OpenAnswers, "
Return your answer in the following format:
Category: [Fairness / Revenge / Normalization / None of the Above]
Explanation: [brief explanation here]

Prior to the LLM-assisted deductive coding, we also employed an abductive thematic coding procedure following the guideline of Thompson (2022). The process of abductive thematic coding involved several structured steps. First, both coders familiarized themselves with the data by reading through the open responses in detail. This was followed by multiple rounds of initial coding, during which the coders assigned descriptive labels to segments of the data using MAXQDA software. Based on these codes, the coders collaborated to develop a comprehensive and systematic codebook, which is presented in Table J2. Each code was given a clear label, a description of when the code applies, keywords that characterize the code, and some examples to further illustrate its application. To enhance reliability, all open answers were re-coded using this finalized codebook. The inter-coder reliability, based on a random subset of the open answers (i.e., 20%) which were analyzed by both coders, was good with a Krippendorff's alpha coefficient of 0.701. Finally, we analyzed the relationships and patterns among the codes to synthesize broader themes that provide a meaningful theoretical interpretation of respondents' motivations for reciprocating democratic transgressions. The replication material provides an overview of all the open answers and their assigned codes.

Importantly, the results from this abductive manual coding process directly informed the construction of the LLM prompt used for the deductive analysis. Specifically, we randomly selected segments of open-ended responses that had been assigned particular codes and included these as illustrative examples in the prompt. Rather than relying on externally developed dictionaries, the prompt example markers were thus grounded in the manually coded data. This resulted in a few-shot prompting approach, in which the model is provided with labeled examples prior to classification to guide its coding decisions.

Although the GPT-assisted deductive coding was directly informed by the abductive thematic analysis, the two approaches differ in important ways. Most notably, the abductive analysis produced a richer set of categories that extends beyond the three theoretical mechanisms captured in the deductive scheme. Specifically, the abductive coding identified additional themes (e.g., utility-based motivations and protecting the country and democracy) that were not preregistered as theoretical mechanisms and therefore not included as separate categories in the GPT prompt. Moreover, within the fairness category, the abductive coding further distinguished between three subcategories (i.e., tit-for-tat, equal outcome, and fair response), whereas the GPT-assisted coding collapsed these into a single fairness category.

Table J2. Codebook abductive thematic coding

Code	Description	Example(s)	Keywords
Tit for tat	Answers saying they should reciprocate because the Out-Party did it first, not offering any explanation beyond that. This code gets overruled if another code is present (except for *Policy Related* or *Unclear*),	"It's fairly simple, it's an eye for an eye type of thing. If they're doing it to you, you should be able to do it to them." "tit for tat" "Fight fire with fire"	tit for tat, eye for an eye, fight fire with fire, what's good for the goose is good for the gander, return the

	except in cases where it is really two separate explanations.	"Because they seem to be doing the same thing"	favour, retaliate, reciprocate, mirror
Equal outcome	To create an equal political sphere with the same chances for everyone/ Respondents express that reciprocating the transgression is fair in order to level the playing fields.	"Because they are doing the same so it would even the playing fields" "To make the situation fair and even reducing the opportunities to the same level" "To counteract the labour law"	level playing field, balancing the scores, make it even, reducing bias, counteracting.
Fair response	Similar to equal outcome, but focusing on the fairness of the response in this specific context. Often, these responses focus on the fairness of the specific reciprocal act itself, rather than the fairness of the resulting democratic context.	"What's fair is fair" "This would be the fair thing to do" "It's fair game. If the conservatives are implementing that labour should too" "They should do the same as its not fair for one party to do it and not the other"	Fair is fair, just, right thing to do, do the same
Policy related	Respondent is only talking about the specific policy/issue, not offering any justifications that go beyond this issue. These responses demonstrate support for the democratic transgression, irrespective of the behavior of the out-party. Also, this code gets overruled if there is any other code (except for *Unclear*) present.	"I don't like protests" "Labour Party should take action to prohibit critical right-leaning news outlets as they will report negativity about the Labour Party"	
Protect country & democracy: Deterrence	Applies when the justification is to make the out-party see the error of their ways, or to prevent the opposing party from engaging in transgressions again in the future. The reciprocal act is intended to enforce/promote democratic behavior from the opponent going forward.	"I think that if they don't take action to do this then the Conservative party is more likely to keep doing actions against the Green party not expecting retaliation" "It would give the conservative party a reason to do the same thing again or something even worse" "They have to do the same to show how ridiculous it is"	See the error of their ways, send a message/signal, pre-emptive, can't get away with it, change course.
Protect country & democracy: Prevent out-party harm	These responses often argue that stopping the opponent is in the broader interest of the country and democracy. Sometimes, respondents highlight that their in-party does a better job at acting in the country's interest.	"Because the conservatives are ruining the country" "I'm just in favour of labour and feel that the conservatives are damaging the country"	
Utility: Winning the game	This category includes responses that highlight the strategic benefit of reciprocating the transgression in terms of political benefit or advantages. Often, the need to win (elections) is stressed.	"If the Republicans sat back and did nothing they would end up losing all of their political power as the Democrats would keep pressing their advantage, so they have to respond in kind." "to ensure labour don't get in power" "If they do not do anything, they will likely lose the election"	Power, winning, advantage, benefit, rational, strategic.
Utility: Reputation	Reciprocating to promote a certain image for the preferred party. Applies when respondents express concerns around seeming weak or when the importance of appearing strong is stressed.	"To show them that they will not just back down" "Otherwise Labour would look weak compared to them."	Don't look weak, don't back down, show strength, don't take it, walk over.
Revenge	This category includes responses that voice a general disapproval and sometimes hate of the opposing party. The focus is on punishing the opponents. Often, these responses highlight the need for the out-party to suffer from their prior undemocratic behavior. These responses can have a more frustrated and emotional undertone.	"On that note, in response to outright fascism, we should respond as aggressively as the other side." "I want the Tories to suffer" "It's payback for the previous situation shown"	have a taste of own medicine, retaliate, fight fire with fire, payback, fight back, don't let them get away with it, hate, swear words.
Other: Answer options	Statements wishing for another option than the ones given or wishing to reverse the undemocratic behavior of the out-party.	"There should've been an option to pass the prohibiting hindrance of voting" 'Neither law should be passed"	Repealed, reverse, stopped, overturn.

Other: Unclear	A category for all answers that do not make sense. This can include responses with unintelligible or meaningless writing, or answers that do not seem to fit the actual question that they were asked. This also includes respondents who have changed their minds about their response to the previous question.

Turning to the findings of the abductive coding, we identified 948 extracts with 12 different codes across the open responses (Individual open answers could contain multiple codes, hence the slightly higher number). These codes were organized into six overarching themes: Fairness, policy, protect the country & democracy, revenge, utility, and other. As we do not document notable cross-country differences, Figure J1 displays the frequency of the codes and how they are situated in their respective themes for both countries combined.

With 54 percent of the extracts falling into this category, the most prominent theme to explain respondents' support for reciprocal transgressions is 'Fairness'**.** This theme encompasses responses that frame the reciprocation of transgressions as a morally justifiable course of action. Respondents within this category report to adhere to reciprocity-standards as a way to determine what is an acceptable and right way to react. We identified three subcategories within this broader overarching theme: tit for tat, equal outcome and fair response.

Responses in the tit-for-tat subcategory emphasize reciprocity as a fundamental societal rule that justifies responding to democratic transgressions in kind. Within this category, reciprocation is viewed as a necessary and instinctive response to undemocratic behavior by the opposing party. For instance, one participant wrote down, "I think it is a do unto them as they do unto you. It shouldn't be a one way street and both should be heard, but if one is stifled, then the other should be as well".

Responses classified under 'equal outcome' focus on the broader systemic impact of reciprocation, emphasizing how reciprocal actions can level the political playing field and prevent one party from having an unfair advantage. This perspective views reciprocal acts as a corrective mechanism to address imbalances in the political sphere, aiming to restore a sense of equality. For instance, one respondent stated, "In the spirit of fairness, and democracy, there should not be rules for one party and not the other. If Democrats restrict certain news outlets from attending, then Republicans should be allowed the same option". In contrast, responses categorized under 'fair response' center on the intrinsic fairness of the reciprocal act itself, independent of its broader political consequences. Here, the act of reciprocation is justified as an appropriate and symmetrical response to the initial transgression. As one respondent remarked, "I feel like if the democrats are doing it then it is only fair for our party to do the same thing".

The second most prominent theme, accounting for 14 percent of extracts, reflects policy-based preferences, where respondents express support for the democratic transgression regardless of the opponent's prior undemocratic act. These responses voice a general approval for stricter voting regulations, dissatisfaction with protests, or discontent with the media, highlighting a motivation rooted more in individual policy preferences than in any reciprocal logic. This theme is also prevalent amongst respondents who endorsed transgressions in the control group and can hence be considered part of the support baseline.

Next, within the theme of Protecting the Country and Democracy**,** reciprocal transgressions tend to be framed as a means to safeguard democratic principles. Some respondents suggest that failing to respond in kind could embolden the out-group to continue undermining democracy, making reciprocal transgressions a necessary measure to maintain

democratic stability (i.e., deterrence). Relatedly, respondents within this theme often view reciprocation as a defense mechanism against perceived threats posed by the political opponent. These responses portray the opposing party as a danger to the nation, with reciprocal actions as a means to mitigate harm and protect national interests. Interestingly, this self-reported justification was overrepresented amongst more affectively polarized respondents (Table J3).



Figure J1. Sunburst plot providing frequencies of themes and codes.

In line with our theoretical framework, we also identified revenge as a theme, where respondents express a desire for the opposing party to suffer the consequences of their undemocratic actions. Additionally, some respondents cited utility-related arguments for reciprocating, such as improving their party's chances of winning an election or enhancing its reputation. Finally, an other-category includes responses that were unclear (e.g., gibberish) or advocated an alternative course of action. Notably, we did not document clear evidence of the theorized normalization process. We offer two possible interpretations of this finding. First, the absence of explicit normalization rhetoric may itself be substantively meaningful, suggesting that the treatment effects observed in the main analysis are driven primarily by fairness-based reasoning rather than by a process of normalization. Consistent with this interpretation, we also do not find a significant effect of the democratic information treatment on citizens' support for reciprocal transgressions. Second, and more cautiously, normalization may operate through implicit or subconscious processes that are unlikely to be explicitly articulated in self-reported justifications (Bicchieri, 2017). Respondents who have internalized democratic transgressions as normal may not consciously recognize or report this as a motivation, making open-ended responses a limited instrument for detecting normalization.

Table J3. Open question extracts and deviations from the mean of affective polarization levels

	Affective polarization (standardized)
Equal outcome	-0.069
Fair response	-0.102
Tit for tat	-0.003
Policy	-0.014
Deterrence	0.067
Prevent out-party harm	0.339
Revenge	0.126
Reputation	0.034
Winning	0.173

K. Closed-ended questions: Motivations to reciprocate transgressions

As pre-registered, we also include closed-ended questions in the survey in England to tap into respondents' motivations to reciprocate democratic transgressions. Though the open-ended responses offer more nuanced insights by allowing participants to freely articulate their reasoning without being influenced by predefined response options, the closed-ended questions enable a direct assessment of whether the opponent's democratic violation shaped perceptions of fairness, revenge, and normalization. Table K1 provides an overview of the question wording in the survey.

Table K2 shows the results of regression models (i.e., OLS regressions, as well as Poisson regressions, to account for the skew in the distribution of the dependent variables). We find that exposure to undemocratic behaviour by an opponent makes English citizens more inclined to believe that a democratic transgression by their own party (1) restores fairness in politics, (2) is necessary to punish the opponent, and (3) is a normal way to react in politics. Though these results should be interpreted with caution due to their exploratory nature, they suggest that fairness, revenge, and normalization all contribute to support for reciprocal transgressions. While the effect sizes are somewhat larger for normalization relative to fairness and revenge, the confidence intervals overlap and preclude us from ruling one mechanism as more important than the others on the basis of this test. These findings deviate somewhat from the analysis of the open-ended responses, which provides less clear evidence that normalization plays a role in justifying reciprocal transgressions. One possible explanation is that normalization often operates subconsciously, making respondents less likely to explicitly mention it in an open-ended format. Alternatively, this discrepancy may stem from a limitation of our normalization indicator, which can capture either personal endorsement of the reciprocal act as being 'normal' or a broader perception that it is simply common among politicians—regardless of whether respondents themselves approve of reciprocation.

Table K1. Question wording: Motivations to reciprocate transgressions open-ended & closed-ended

Variables	Survey item	Answer options
Motivations to reciprocate transgressions: open-ended	In the last survey question, you reported that you believe: [selected answer on either protest, vote, or press]. Please provide a brief explanation for your answer.	[open text field]

Motivations to reciprocate transgressions: Closed-ended (England only)	Imagine that [in-party] would decide to take action to [undemocratic answer option]. To what extent would you agree with the following statements: - This restores fairness in politics. - This is necessary to punish [out-party]. - This is a normal way to react in politics.	5-point scale ranging from (1) Strongly disagree to (5) Strongly agree.

Table K2. Effects of the treatment on fairness, revenge, & normalization motivations (England only)

	Fairness		Revenge		Normalization	
	OLS	Poisson	OLS	Poisson	OLS	Poisson
treatment	0.425***	0.202***	0.406***	0.193***	0.543***	0.237***
	(0.037)	(0.022)	(0.037)	(0.022)	(0.038)	(0.021)
Constant	1.901***	0.642***	1.909***	0.646***	2.030***	0.708***
	(0.026)	(0.016)	(0.026)	(0.016)	(0.027)	(0.016)
Observations	4005	4005	4005	4005	4002	4002

Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

L. Democratic consistency: Reciprocating transgressions while supporting democracy?

We test whether transgressions by political opponents also affect citizens' more abstract support for democracy. Table L1 shows the exact wording of the questions in the survey in both the US and England. The results of OLS regression models are presented in Table L2, and the results of Poisson regressions that account for the skewed dependent variable are presented in Table L3 (dependent variables are reverse coded). The three different democratic support items form a reliable scale in both England ($\alpha = .89$) and the US ($\alpha = .89$).

We do not document a significant effect of the treatment on citizens' general support for democracy: Respondents in the control group do not agree more strongly that (1) it is important to live in a country that is governed democratically, (2) a democratic political system is a good way of governing the UK or US, or (3) democracy is better than any other form of government. At first glance, these findings may seem paradoxical: Respondents in the treatment group become more supportive of democratic transgressions by their own political camp while remaining committed to democracy in the abstract. Yet, these results align closely with the observation in existing literature that citizens tend to behave like 'questionnaire democrats': When asked in abstract terms, citizens often profess to hold sincere democratic preferences, but when confronted with concrete scenarios and trade-offs, these commitments seem to waver (e.g., Graham & Svolik 2020; Krishnarajan 2023).

Table L1. Question wording: Democratic support

Variables	Survey item	Answer options
Democratic support	To what extent do you agree with the following statements? - Item 1: It is important to live in a country that is governed democratically. - Item 2: A democratic political system is a good way of governing the [UK/US]. - Item 3: Democracy may have problems, but it is better than any other form of government.	5-point scale ranging from (1) Strongly disagree to (5) Strongly agree.

Table L2. Abstract support for democracy, OLS regressions

	England				United States			
	DemSup	Item 1	Item 2	Item 3	DemSup	Item 1	Item 2	Item 3
Treatment	-0.011	0.008	-0.031	-0.010	0.005	0.025	0.006	-0.019
	(0.024)	(0.024)	(0.026)	(0.028)	(0.029)	(0.030)	(0.032)	(0.032)
Constant	4.377***	4.503***	4.368***	4.260***	4.283***	4.380***	4.250***	4.220***
	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.019)	(0.020)	(0.020)	(0.021)	(0.023)	(0.023)
Observations	4003	4003	4003	4003	4020	4021	4020	4021

Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table L3. Abstract support for democracy (reverse coded), Poisson regressions

	England				United States			
	DemSup	Item 1	Item 2	Item 3	DemSup	Item 1	Item 2	Item 3
Treatment	0.018	-0.016	0.048	0.014	-0.006	-0.042	-0.009	0.024
	(0.040)	(0.045)	(0.039)	(0.037)	(0.037)	(0.040)	(0.036)	(0.035)
Constant	-0.473***	-0.700***	-0.458***	-0.301***	-0.332***	-0.477***	-0.287***	-0.248***
	(0.028)	(0.032)	(0.028)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.028)	(0.026)	(0.025)
Observations	4003	4003	4003	4003	4020	4021	4020	4021

Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

M. Threat perceptions of the political opponent

In the US, we examine whether the treatment significantly heightens respondents' perception that the out-party poses a serious threat to the country's well-being. Specifically, we ask respondents: *"To what extent do you view the [out-party] as a serious threat to the country's well-being?"* using a 101-point scale ranging from *"Not at all"* (0) to *"A great deal"* (100). The OLS regression results in Table M1 indicate that respondents in the treatment group perceive the out-party as a greater threat to the country compared to those in the control group. Notably, even among control respondents, the average rating is 71.33 (SD = 27.25), indicating that many in the control condition already view the opposing party as a significant democratic threat.

Table M1. Out-party threat, OLS regression

	United States Out-party Threat
Treatment	1.959*
	(0.850)
Constant	71.329***
	(0.601)
Observations	4023

Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

N. Reciprocation on a different level of democracy

Our main hypothesis examines whether citizens tend to reciprocate transgressions that directly mirror the initial violation committed by the political opponent. However, as pre-registered, we also investigate whether citizens extend their reciprocity beyond the specific domain of the initial transgression by responding on 'a different level of democracy'. For instance, we test whether citizens who are shown a transgression by the out-party on the topic of protests are also more likely to support a reciprocal transgression by the in-party on the topic of voting rights or freedom of the press. In terms of our experimental design, respondents first answer the main dependent variable, indicating their support for mirrored reciprocal transgressions, followed by an open-ended question explaining their motivation. Next, they are assigned to additional dependent variables in a randomized order, which includes a measure that taps into respondents' support for a democratic transgression on a different domain than the specific out-party violation shown to the respondent in the vignette.

Results from multinomial regressions based on the U.S. survey data are presented in Table N1. We do not find a significant effect of the treatment on support for transgressions in a different democratic domain. While this could suggest that citizens are only willing to directly mirror out-party transgressions, it is important to acknowledge the limitations of our design. Since citizens first express their support for mirrored reciprocal transgressions, they may feel that they have already conveyed their discontent by retaliating in kind, making further transgressions in a different democratic domain seem unnecessary or excessive. For a more accurate test, future studies could refine the design by asking citizens immediately after the treatment whether they support transgressions in a different democratic domain.

Table N1. Support for democratic transgression on a different level of democracy

	United States Combined
Undemocratic	
Treatment	0.071
	(0.105)
Don't know	
Treatment	0.041
	(0.126)
Observations	4026

Exponentiated coefficients (Relative Risk Ratios); Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

O. Real-life examples of vignettes and realism

Our vignettes focus on three types of democratic transgressions: (1) taking action to prohibit protests by political opponents, (2) proposing laws that restrict the voting rights of supporters of the opposing party, and (3) denying access to critical media during a press briefing. Table O1 provides real-life examples of each type of transgression in both England and the US, supported by news sources. These cases illustrate that the scenarios we present are realistic within the political contexts of our selected countries and grounded in actual events. Importantly, the examples in Table O1 are illustrative rather than exhaustive; we do not attempt to catalogue all historical instances of these behaviors. The realism of our scenarios is also reflected in respondents' responses. In the US, we directly measured perceived realism on a scale from 0 ("not realistic at all") to 100 ("extremely realistic"). A large majority – 70 percent – rated the vignette at 50 or higher, with an average realism score of 61. Figure O1 presents the corresponding density plot. Perceived realism was not measured in England.

Table O1. Real-life examples of democratic transgressions

	England	United States
Protests	- Legislation that critics argued amounted to pre-emptive suppression of protests by especially environmental movements. - Legislation that lowered the threshold for police intervention in public protest, which was ruled unlawful by the UK Court.	- Florida's 'anti-riot' law championed by Republican Governor Ron DeSantis. - A law in Oklahoma which grants immunity to motorists who unintentionally kill protestors, which critics say is intended to limit demonstrations.
Voting rights	- The Elections Act 2022, which critics argued would suppress votes and disproportionately affect poor and young voters.	- Academic work on voter suppression in the US (Epperly et al. 2019). - Georgia's Election Integrity Act of 2021, which negatively impacted people of color. - Florida Senate Bill 90.
Freedom of the Press	- Boris Johnson's aides banned selected reporters from attending a Downing Street Briefing. - The UK government blacklisted a group of investigative journalists and denied them access to information.	- The White House blocked Associated Press journalists from sticking with the name "Gulf of Mexico". Source. - The White house revoked the press pass of CNN's chief White House reporter. - U.S. Press Freedom Tracker documents 117 incidents of access to government events.

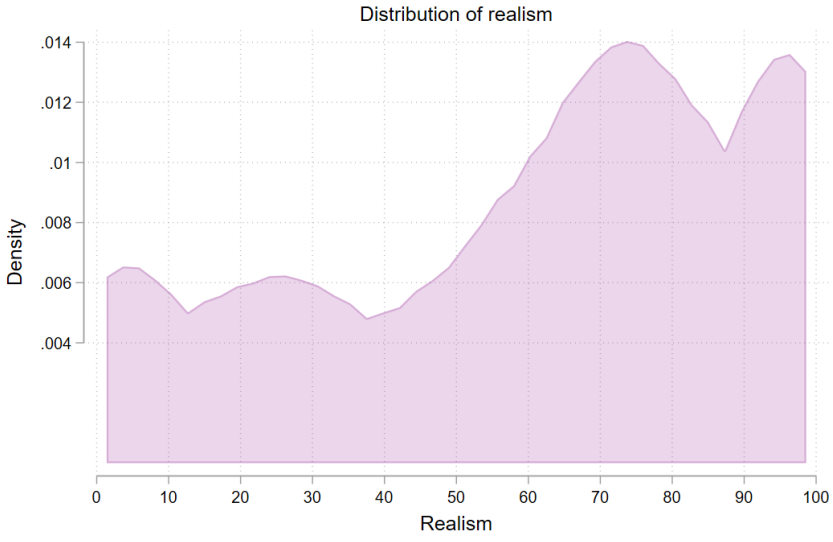


Figure O1. Density plot of the realism of the vignettes in the US

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